Chicken

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/51448303.

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Explicit

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Bow (She-Ra), Adora & Glimmer (She-Ra)

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90s, POV Adora (She-Ra), Alternate Universe - High School, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, House Party, comphet, First Time, Drinking, Coming Out, Coming of Age, Finger Sucking, Hair-pulling, Grinding, Vaginal Fingering, Biting, Falling In Love, Praise Kink, Smut, Fluff, Minor Love Triangle, It's the 90s man shit was rough, Pretending to Be Gay, Some ethically dubious relationship stuff fair warning, Implied/Referenced Alcohol Abuse/Alcoholism, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Implied/Referenced Homophobia, Human Catra (She-Ra), United States

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by ari_kari

Summary

Winter, 1996. It's the semester before graduation, and Adora is bonding over drinks with a few soccer teammates. Out of nowhere, one of them brings up a game that Adora's never heard of before - "gay chicken."

Naturally, Adora has questions.

Notes

welcome to whatever the fuck this is >:) check tags for trigger warnings, as they're pretty consistent throughout the fic. Enjoy.

(Follow @ari-kari on Tumblr for more fic updates)

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Gay *what?*"

Adora assumes she's misheard. Which is a fair assumption - it is *way* too loud in here. She'd figured a party thrown by Perfuma would be a little bit more lowkey on the music end of things, but she seems to be one of those people who loses hearing sensitivity as she drinks. She's been blasting Enya on her boombox at max volume for about an hour now.

"Y'know." Mermista gestures vaguely to her surroundings, her wine sloshing a bit in the glass. "Gay chicken."

Adora furrows her brows. Everyone seems to be nodding.

"That clarifies absolutely nothing."

"Damn. You really were living under a rock," Glimmer mutters, her words muffled by her beer can as she takes another sip.

Adora tries to ignore her. Things had been weird between them for a while now - pretty much from the moment Adora had started seeing Bow, so longer than she'd like. The liquor didn't seem to be helping things.

"It's not like we don't have, like, civilization back home," Adora insists defensively. "This is probably just a local thing."

Glimmer just tips the remainder of the can into her mouth. Her features are sullen. "Mermista's from the east coast."

Adora sighs.

Glimmer had been Adora's first friend when she'd had to switch schools - switch states - at the beginning of senior year. Making varsity soccer as a complete unknown had been sort of a nightmare, but Glimmer had gone to great lengths to bring Adora into the fold. With her support, Adora had gone from being a random interloper to a fully-fledged member of the team in less than a month.

Of course Adora had blown it.

"Be nice to her," a low voice to her right purrs. "Adora's from Montana. They still send their gays to the electric chair."

Adora feels herself flush as the room laughs; she covers with an eye roll and a sip of beer. Getting teased by Catra feels different than getting teased by Glimmer, even as she makes a conscious effort to ignore them both. Better, somehow. She doesn't fully understand why.

"Are you guys ever going to tell me what this is?" Adora eventually gripes, once the chuckles have died down a bit.

Mermista rolls her eyes. But eventually, she leans forward to grab her plastic wine flute - clearly preparing to deliver some kind of 'lesson'. Once she's settled back into the couch, she begins.

"So you know chicken?" She takes a prolonged sip. "That game that, like, douchebag boys used to play in middle school, where they'd run full speed at each other and give themselves concussions?"

Adora nods. She knows all too well - going up against those "douchebag boys", and winning, had been one of her favorite sideline activities in junior leagues. She had the yellow cards to prove it.

"Well," Mermista continues, her voice taking on a suggestive lilt. "Gay chicken's a lot like that. Only instead of slamming foreheads, you're, uh…slamming other things."

It takes a while for the information to sink in.

"OK." She feels her pulse beginning to pick up, for some reason. "So…just to make sure I understand. Gay chicken is two girls having sex?"

The outcry is immediate.

"Woah -"

"It's not -"

"*Jesus*, Adora!"

Adora feels herself blushing. "Well, I - what is it, then?"

"It's kissing," Perfuma pipes up from the back, a little giggly from her wine. "If that. People don't actually get to the point of… anything else. Someone always chickens out before then."

"Depends on who's playing."

Everyone turns to Catra.

She's always had a way of commanding the room when she talks. Maybe it's the way she dresses - cool and punkish, her short hair and makeup in perfect disarray. Maybe it's the way you can just tell, without even asking, that she's seen and done more in her eighteen years of life than Adora ever will.

Whatever it is, it kind of takes Adora's breath away. She'd kill to have that sort of effect on people.

"Speaking from experience?" Glimmer asks, a note of irony in her voice.

Catra just shrugs.

"I mean…" The corners of her lips quirk upwards. "I can't say I've ever lost. And I've gone up against some *very* determined opponents."

Adora's mouth is suddenly a bit dry. She sips her beer; it only seems to make the feeling worse.

"Don't know why I'm surprised," Mermista drawls, leaning back against the couch. "What's the farthest you've ever gotten?"

A careless grin spreads across Catra's face. Adora can't help but fixate on her eyes as she ponders the question. They're totally different colors; one a deep blue, one a golden shade of hazel. Stunning.

Maybe it's about time Adora switched to water.

"Sorry, Mermista." For a moment, Adora could almost swear Catra's caught her looking - but her eyes flicker forward a second later. "That's a trade secret. Gotta maintain my competitive edge."

The group lets out a collective groan. Whether it's from exasperation or disappointment, Adora can't tell.

"Come on, you buzzkill. No one here is actually going to challenge you to a kiss-off." Mermista rolls her eyes. "Pretty sure no one in this room would stand a chance. And I include myself in that."

There's a strange feeling in Adora's gut now as the room murmurs its agreement. If she didn't know better, she'd think it was nausea from the beer. But nausea didn't usually *spark* like this, did it? It didn't drive her to speak up in a moment where she'd normally be very, *very* quiet.

"I would."

All eyes swivel towards her.

There's an intense beat of silence. Adora can already feel her cheeks going pink, but she fights to keep herself steady. No backing out now.

In the end, it's Glimmer who breaks the silence.

"*What?*"

Adora just shrugs.

"I mean, of course I'm not going to. I have a boyfriend." She goes for another sip, hoping it comes across as casual rather than nervous. "But if I *could* go against you, there's no question. You'd lose."

The energy in the air is more charged than it was before.

"She's bluffing," Glimmer insists, waving a hand dismissively. She looks a bit more sloshed than she was a few minutes ago; her sparkly eyeshadow's seen better days. "I've seen her kiss Bow. It's like watching someone say goodbye to their auntie at the family Christmas party."

That stings. People laugh, but there's a nervous edge to it - like they aren't quite sure if they're supposed to.

"And anyways," Glimmer continues, refusing to meet her eyes, "I thought you guys were just 'seeing what happened.' Since when is he your actual boyfriend?'

"I…it's complicated." Adora's definitely feeling uncomfortable now. "Complicated enough that I wouldn't want to hook up with my teammate in Perfuma's living room."

Catra's eyebrows shoot upward.

"So we're hooking up now?"

A shiver passes through Adora's body. She suppresses it - internally and externally. By the time she speaks again, her voice is deadly calm.

"Depends on how desperate you are not to lose."

The group is totally silent. Enya blares on in the background.

"…Why?" Perfuma's expression is hard to place. It seems to be hovering between fascination and concern. "Why would you do that?"

Adora has the vague sense that the question is a bit more loaded than she'd like it to be. Maybe more than she'd like to consider, right at this moment. But forfeit is not an option. She has to buckle down.

"I know I'm still kind of new here," Adora offers. She begins to run her finger around the mouth of her beer bottle - round and round. "You'd have no way of knowing this yet. But I actually don't lose. Like…ever."

She has no idea how that plays with the group - she's not looking at them. Her gaze is still locked on Catra, whose eyes seem to have taken on a new shine.

"Everyone loses," Catra replies easily. But her expression betrays her interest. "That's just life. No offense, princess, but I've watched you fumble a few saves myself."

There's a round of chuckles - and a loud, unattractive snort from Glimmer. But Adora isn't phased. She just smiles.

"I'm not talking about technique, or strength. That's not really something I have control over in the moment." She lifts her beer again. "But endurance? Those dumb little challenges most people tap out on? I'll go until I die. Always."

Adora doesn't know what game she's playing right now, staring Catra down like this. It's not one she's played before. But the liquor's made her bold. And in spite of it all, she finds she doesn't particularly want to stop.

Maybe Catra doesn't either.

"Shame you won't be able to prove it," Catra says. Her voice is smooth as she looks Adora up and down. "Sorry, princess. Without any followthrough, you're pretty much all talk."

And that finally breaks Adora's trance - makes her blood stop humming with that strange new allure. Because she's not going to kiss Catra, at the end of the day. Like she's said from the start.

Her body just seemed to have forgotten for a moment, for some reason.

"Don't need your validation, anyways," Adora replies, trying and failing to keep her voice as collected as Catra's. "I may be benched right now, but I know my abilities. You'd get trounced."

Catra places her hand on her heart, puckering her lip in a display of false sympathy. "Of course I would. You're the champion of all our hearts, Adora. A gay chicken extraordinaire."

There are a few tipsy laughs around the circle; the energy in the room seems to ease a bit. Adora is prepared to move on - a little disappointed, for reasons she'd rather not analyze.

Then a voice from the corner speaks up.

"You could always ask him."

They all turn to look.

A few of the teams' defenders - Octavia and Lonnie - had been playing what looked to be an absolutely disastrous round of Super Mario Kart on the opposite end of the room. Now, though, it seems that Lonnie is fully invested in the conversation. She's leaning with her arms against the chairback, eyebrows raised; a diabolical gleam shines in her eye.

"I - what?"

"Ask Bow." Lonnie's face stretches into a sloppy grin. She's definitely had a few. "As in, call him. Right now."

"And say what?" Adora asks incredulously. Suddenly, her pulse seems to have picked up. "Hey babe, are we *actually* dating? And

if so, can I, like…cheat on you with Catra Weaver, in Perfuma's living room?"

Lonnie just shrugs.

"Not cheating if you get permission first."

"*Okay*, everyone," Perfuma chimes in. She's looking a bit flushed. "While I love and support - erm - *all* people, I'm going to have to draw a few lines here. As in…sexual ones. In my mother's living room, specifically."

"Sounds pretty homophobic to me, Perf," Catra replies, without missing a beat. She's looking at Adora again. "You sure you're not allowing your worldly biases to hamper your connection to the wider universe?"

Everyone snickers as Perfuma begins to sputter an excuse. "I - no! Of course not! I am not - I would never *dream* of -"

"It's not like she'd get that far anyways," Glimmer interrupts. There's a definite slur to her voice now. "Even if Bow allowed something like that, she'd never actually *do* it."

And oh - Glimmer must have known what that statement would provoke in her. Adora's way too tipsy to let such a blatant challenge go unheeded. And she can't help but notice that Catra is still staring at her, and she has this *look* on her face, and the energy that's been coursing through Adora's veins these past few minutes is very quickly reaching a boiling point.

So she turns to Perfuma - as composed as humanly possible - and asks, "Can I use your phone?"

You can practically hear the gears freezing in everyone's heads.

"Adora." Her eyes flicker to a spot over Adora's shoulder - towards the phone on the wall, if Adora had to guess. "Are you absolutely certain this is what you want?"

When she puts it like that, it makes the whole thing sound pretty serious. And for some reason, Adora likes that. It feels serious, what she's doing. She just wishes she understood why.

"I am," she says confidently. Then she lowers her voice. "I'm not gonna have aggressive lesbian sex in your living room, Perfuma. I'm not a total psychopath."

This seems to reassure Perfuma - somewhat. But there's still a beat of pause. She narrows her eyes slightly at Adora, as if assessing her.

"On one condition." Her eyes flicker to the telephone, then back. "You have to walk all the way to the phone in a completely straight line. Like you're on a tight rope. Then, and only then, will I grant you my blessing."

There's a round of "oohs" and chuckles. Adora rolls her eyes.

"I've literally had two beers," she mumbles. "But fine. I accept your challenge. You have to turn down Enya, though."

Perfuma grins. Then she stands up, and heads toward the boombox without another word.

Adora turns toward the phone, steeling her shoulders. The rest of the group is regarding her with looks ranging from exasperation to glee. Catra has her arms crossed, an amused expression in her face. Adora feels the strange need to impress her.

She takes a deep breath. Lets it out. And begins to walk.

It's a short distance to the phone. Probably about ten steps, at most. But it's long enough for Adora to finally start to question things. To realize exactly what she's gotten herself into with all of this.

The game itself is fine. The game itself, she wants - even if she's not ready to ask herself *why* that is. But there are obstacles to be overcome in the process that she's significantly less confident

about. And they become more and more real with every step towards the phone.

She's been seeing Bow, semi-officially, for about three weeks now. And it's been…good. She likes him a lot; likes his kindness, and his determination, and his dorky sense of humor. It'd seemed almost inevitable that they'd wind up dating, with all the time they spent together beforehand. Outside of Glimmer - and really, who knew what *they* were anymore - he's probably her best friend.

Why is she doing this?

It's almost enough to make her back down. Even this call alone might be enough to hurt him, if she didn't play her cards right. And her pride didn't extend to throwing him under the bus just to secure some sort of personal glory. She wasn't *that* big of an asshole

But then, she's at the phone - having crossed the floor in ten perfect, steady strides. Enya has finally been turned down enough that she can hear the group cheering behind her. And when she glances back, Catra is still looking at her. Her bright eyes pop beneath the dark smoke of her eye makeup. They make Adora weak.

She picks up the phone from its receiver, and dials the number from memory.

It doesn't matter anyways, Adora thinks, as the phone begins to ring. Bow will never be OK with this. And when he isn't, Adora will apologize incessantly for even *thinking* to bring it up, and everything will be fine, and they can all go back to getting wasted on Miller and gossiping about Coach Huntara's love life.

Maybe he wouldn't even -

The ringing stops.

"Hey, Perfuma. What's up?"

Her heart warms a little at the words. Of course Bow, of all people, would have his friends' numbers memorized. He's just that kind of guy.

"Hey babe," she says, her voice a little strained. "It's me. Adora."

Behind her, the group begins to cheer - mostly just whooping, with a few random *babe*'s thrown in for good measure. Adora feels her face go red.

"Hey!" The genuine excitement in his voice makes her heart fall. "What are you doing at Perfuma's?"

"Oh, that's - it's nothing," Adora stammers. "Practice let out early today, so a few of us decided to have a little, uh…party. Thing. It's just -"

"*ADORA HAS A QUESTION*."

Lonnie had appeared behind her out of nowhere; she shouts so close to Adora's ear that she jumps.

"*Jesus!*" Adora hisses.

"Is that Lonnie?" Bow laughs on the other end. "Hey, Lonnie!"

"Hey, Bow," Lonnie says, in a singsong voice that absolutely would not be there if she wasn't already about four drinks in.

Adora shoos her away like an annoying gnat, earning a few laughs from the group. She huffs out a breath and turns her attention back to the phone.

"You had a question?" Bow's voice is painfully genuine.

Adora swallows.

"Right. So - question." Suddenly, it's as if her brain has turned to mush. "Do you know - uh - have you ever heard of gay chicken?"

A beat of silence.

"Yeah?" Bow's voice is cheerful, but there's a slight nervous edge to it now. "Of course. Why?"

Adora takes a deep breath. When she speaks, the words come rushing out of her.

"So you know how I have to win, right? Like, no matter what. Have we talked about that? I feel like we have."

To Adora's surprise, she hears a low chuckle coming from the other end.

"Someone challenged your honor again, didn't they?"

Relief - and affection - swell in Adora's heart.

"Yeah. They did." Her voice sounds a bit whiny. "They don't believe that I can win. Just because I'm from Montana - like that's *my* fault. It's totally unfair!"

She can hear the smile in Bow's voice when he speaks, even through the concern.

"Adora, how tipsy are you right now, exactly?"

Adora pauses a moment. She focuses all her energy on articulating the syllables that come from her mouth.

"Not enough to jeopardize my consent."

Lonnie is back now - along with a few others, Mermista included. They are leaning obnoxiously close to the mouthpiece in an effort to hear both sides of the conversation.

"That's good," Bow says, as Adora tries and fails to scare them away with an intimidating glare. "So, you're calling me…what, to ask my permission?"

Adora's heart falls a little. "Of course I'm asking your permission. I'd never do something like that without it."

“I know, babe,” Bow says quietly. “I trust you.”

There’s a weight like a stone in Adora’s gut.

“Look, I’m sorry,” Adora begins. “This was dumb. I - I’ll talk to you -”

“I’m cool with it.”

Adora’s eyes widen. Behind her, Perfuma makes an undignified little squeak.

“Wait - really?”

Bow chuckles. To Adora’s relief, his voice is light.

“Yeah, babe. I mean, we never technically made things official anyways. So as far as I’m concerned…take home the gold.”

An excited rush of murmuring breaks out behind her.

“I - wow.” Adora seems to have forgotten how to breath. “OK. I mean -”

“Wait.”

The voice comes from one of the warm bodies pressed against Adora’s flank. She’d known a lot of the girls had gotten closer, but she hadn’t thought to label who was who. Now, the identity of the girl behind her - the girl pressed firmly against her back - was revealed.

Catra.

She reaches over to take the phone before Adora can even process. Her other arm comes to drape casually over Adora’s shoulder.

“Before you agree to anything else,” Catra asks. “How far can she go?”

A warm, tingling thrill travels down the length of Adora's body. Catra's arm is snug and warm on her shoulder.

"Is this Catra?" Bow asks, as the other girls snicker behind them.

Catra's breath tickles her neck. "Nope. It's your mom."

"I literally don't have a mom."

"Then it's your dad."

"Which - OK, never mind. What do you mean?"

Adora can practically feel Catra smirking behind her. She's suddenly hyperaware of the other girl's chest pressing against her back, right beneath her shoulder blades.

"You heard me," Catra teases. "How. Far. Can. She. Go?"

There's a flurry of nervous laughter behind her, but Adora isn't focused on them. This has become a conversation of three.

Bow doesn't answer right away. It sends Adora's heart plummeting straight to her stomach. This was a mistake. It was totally inappropriate, and outright cruel, and she should've never -

"I mean, as far as it takes to win, I guess."

Adora's mouth drops open.

For once, Catra seems surprised. Adora can feel her body still. "No shit?"

"Yeah." Bow sounds a little worried now. "I mean, to be honest, my main concern is what *she's* comfortable with. I don't want her to push herself too far over some stupid game."

A rush of fondness overtakes Adora's body. Of course he's prioritizing her right now, when she's on the cusp of being intimate with someone else. Typical Bow. Typical, amazing Bow.

Suddenly, the fondness curdles into shame.

"Alright, back up," Adora barks suddenly, turning to seize the phone from Catra's grip. "I need to have an adult conversation with my - er, Bow. Go gossip somewhere else."

The crowd disperses quickly, seeming to recognize Adora's sudden need for privacy. Catra hands the phone over without a fight; the brush of their fingers leaves a funny feeling in Adora's chest.

As they all return to their seats, Adora stretches the mouthpiece as far as the chord will allow. Fortunately for her, there's a half-bath just a few steps away. Adora moves over the doorway and sinks to the ground, threading the wire beneath the door as it closes.

She can feel Bow waiting patiently on the other end when she brings the phone to her ear.

"Hey," she says, a bit weakly.

Bow chuckles.

"Hey." A pause. "You doing OK?"

Idiot. Adora was an idiot, for suggesting this in the first place. For bringing Bow into it.

"I'm *fine*, Bow," she insists. "I'm worried about you."

"Adora, we're not even official."

"I know that," Adora says quickly. "But still, I…are you absolutely sure about this? I don't want to hurt you."

There's a pause at the other end that makes Adora feel sick. But when he does speak, it's not what she thinks it's going to be.

"Adora, you know you can talk to me about anything, right?"

All the thoughts in Adora's head seem to still at once. She doesn't know why.

"Yeah." She grips the phone a bit tighter. "Of course. So can you."

Another pause. Then -

"I know we're going out right now. But I…I want you to know that you were my friend before all of that. My best friend. And that always comes first. You get what I'm saying?"

Somehow, she thinks she does - and it makes her stomach feel hollow.

"I don't deserve you," Adora murmurs. She's embarrassed to find that tears seem to be forming at her eyes. "I never have."

"Adora, that's not true." He sighs. "You're a good person. You're one of the best I know."

A tear runs down her face. She brushes it aside, embarrassed despite the lack of audience.

"I think we should probably talk about some things, soon," Bow continues. "Tomorrow, if you're down. But I don't want you to worry about any of that tonight. Just…go kick Catra's ass, yeah?"

Adora feels her pulse begin to race.

"How'd you know it was against her?"

To her surprise, she can hear Bow chuckling on the other end.

"Lucky guess." He pauses. "I love you, 'Dor. No matter what. OK?"

Adora swallows. Even through her haze, she knows this conversation has passed beyond the realm of what it was intended for. They'd always been good at that, her and Bow. Talking about something without even needing to say it.

Bow was wrong. She didn't deserve him.

"I love you, too," Adora murmurs. She fights to keep the shakiness out of her tone. "I mean it. Thank you for…being you."

Bow laughs. "Any time. Just take care of yourself, yeah? Don't push yourself too far."

Adora can't help but chuckle at that. "No promises."

Bow scoffs.

"Whatever, nerd. Just drink water. Let me know when you make it home."

"OK." Adora lets her eyes fall shut. "Bye, Bow."

A brief, warm pause. "Bye, Adora."

The line goes dead.

She takes a moment to ground herself on the cool tile while the music pulses on the other side of the door. She feels a bit like she's hovering on the border between worlds. Everything seems more hazy, yet more real, than it did a few moments before.

She finds her mind drifting, for no reason in particular, to a moment from a few days ago; about two hours into a scorching-hot Saturday practice. Coach Huntara had pulled the defensive line for a minute, instructing them to break into pairs while she ran a few plays with the forwards. Adora hadn't done much passing, though. She was too busy watching the center forward - watching Catra - in motion.

Adora was no stranger to aggression, as a center-back. But watching Catra handle the ball was something else. She was an animal on the field; an apex predator, striking without mercy and throwing everything into her pursuit. Catra played like she acted, and she acted like she *was*. And it made Adora wonder - was Catra born like that? Or did she choose it for herself?

Could Adora be like that, too?

She's on her feet before she even really notices. The music swells to its original volume as she pushes the door open in front of her. They've arranged themselves on the couches again, ostensibly mid-discussion, but they all turn to look when Adora appears. The question in their eyes is obvious.

Adora smiles.

"Get me another drink," she orders. "We're doing this."

The room bursts into cheers.

Immediately, there are eager bodies all around her, asking questions she can't hear. One arm - Lonnie's - hands her an unopened can of Miller Lite. It's still cold from the fridge, rimmed with condensation.

Possessed by a sudden, anxious fever, Adora points the tip of the can downward. She's never actually done this before. But without thinking - without allowing the possibility of failure - she uses her thumb to pierce a hole in the bottom of the can, sending foam spilling out the sides.

"Adora!" she hears Perfuma shriek indignantly, as drunken cheers ring out around them. "The *carpet*!"

Adora doesn't respond - there's no time. She just lifts the can to her mouth, pops the top, and lets the liquid surge straight into her mouth. Like she's done it a hundred times before.

In seconds, the beer is drained. And the room has exploded into loud, frenzied cheers.

She passes the can off to a downright reverent Lonnie, giving Perfuma the most apologetic look she can muster. Fortunately, Perfuma seems to take it in good faith - probably because Adora hadn't spilled that much, in the end. She just gives Adora an exasperated eye roll as she makes her way towards the couch.

Glimmer and Catra are sitting alone on the main sofa; Glimmer has pushed herself into the farthest corner. She seemed to have cracked another beer while Adora was gone. As Adora approaches, she's alarmed to see undisguised contempt in Glimmer's eyes.

"Don't mind me," she mumbles, getting to her feet. "I'll be in the kitchen. Enjoy your freebie."

Adora's heart sinks as Glimmer heads to the other room. She's wobbling a bit as she goes.

There's a definite awkwardness in the air now. Everyone seems to be questioning whether or not to continue. After a moment, Perfuma quietly steps towards the kitchen, ostensibly to check on Glimmer.

Not knowing how to proceed, Adora takes an awkward seat next to Catra on the couch. Her gesture with the beer feels obnoxious, now; crude. All of her confidence seems to have flown out of her like air from a balloon.

Fortunately, Catra is there too - and she's pretty adept at smooth recoveries. She turns towards Adora on the couch, tucking her legs beneath her seat.

"Cute trick," Catra drawls, gesturing vaguely towards Lonnie and the discarded beer can. "Was that part of your mating ritual?"

A few people make suggestive "ooh"-ing noises. Adora can't help but grin, even as her cheeks grow pink. "Sort of. Why, is it working?"

Catra laughs. It's a sweet, rich sound; more genuine than Adora was expecting. She kind of wants to hear it again.

"Maybe." Then she grins. "My turn."

Adora's heart skips a beat.

As the whole room murmurs their interest, Catra leans slowly and effortlessly towards her. She slips a leg over Adora's waist and braces her arms around her neck. When she leans in close, a few shrieks and whistles tear through the crowd.

Just like that, Catra is straddling Adora's lap. And Adora seems to have forgotten how to breathe as a result.

"Place your bets!" she hears Lonnie call drunkenly over the buzzing crowd. "Catra or Adora? The lesbian battle of the ages!"

"There is literally, like, zero contest here," Mermista drawls. "All of my money goes to Catra. Or it would, if I had money."

Someone seems to have turned the boom box to R&B slow jams in the last few minutes. It's the only thing Adora can possibly imagine that's worse to make out to than Enya. But for whatever reason, she's finding herself relatively unbothered by it all. She thinks it's Catra's fingers combing through her ponytail, tugging lightly at the band and letting her hair spill around her shoulders. For some reason, it's making all the other little annoyances around them fade away.

Fortunately, Catra is not nearly so enamored. With her fingers still in Adora's hair, she turns away to call out. "Lonnie, turn that shit off! It's such a boner killer!"

A snicker is heard from behind Catra. But after a moment, she relents; the music changes to something a bit less overtly porny. Catra turns back to look Adora in the eyes

Adora isn't sure what she finds there. But whatever it is, it makes Catra smile.

"Just a reminder that there will be no lesbian sex in my living room!" Perfuma squeaks, barely heard above the chatter. She seems to have returned to the fray. "Anything past first base is strictly bedroom-only!"

“Don’t worry, Perfuma,” Catra says, her voice low and sweet. She runs the backs of her knuckles, teasingly, over Adora’s cheekbone. “This’ll be over quickly.”

It’s a bit alarming, the way Adora’s body seems to be humming to life at her touch. Is this anxiety she’s feeling? Yes, of course it is - the most beautiful girl on the soccer team is straddling her waist right now, while four of her closest friends watch. And she really wants to win, doesn’t she? That’s why her blood is pumping hot beneath her skin right now. Why her breath is quickening alongside her pulse, both racing forward in eager anticipation.

They’ve stalled long enough.

“You gonna make good on that legendary reputation of yours, Weaver?” Adora asks, a bit breathless. “Or am I gonna have to do it myself?”

Maybe there are more jeers. A few whistles here and there. But Adora can’t hear them anymore. Her world has narrowed to the girl in her lap - her dusty freckles, and mismatched eyes, and soft, full lips that are closer now than they’ve ever been.

“Glad you’re excited,” Catra murmurs - too low for anyone but her to hear.

Seconds later, their lips meet.

This will be easy. That is Adora’s first thought as she feels Catra’s mouth slide perfectly against her own, and the room bursts into frantic cheers around them. This will be the easiest game Adora has ever won. Child’s play.

She is *never* going to stop.

It is Adora who presses first into Catra’s mouth, grazing her lips gently with her tongue to nudge them open. The gesture earns a passionate shriek from the audience - from Perfuma, surprisingly - but Adora pays her no attention. She can’t risk getting distracted; forfeiting by mistake. She wants to win. She wants to keep going.

She *needs* to keep going.

Catra's hands are in her hair now, fingernails scraping lightly over her scalp as she kisses deep into Adora's mouth. She has to suppress the moan that rises in her chest as a result. Which is strange - because wouldn't making a scene help her, if this really was just a battle of wills? Adora's having trouble remembering how this game is supposed to work. It's a little hard to focus when Catra is tasting her so eagerly, making soft little sounds of pleasure against her mouth that only Adora can hear. Maybe this is why Catra always wins. She makes you forget you're even playing.

Right. The game. She should probably start trying to win that, now.

Without warning, Adora grasps roughly at Catra's waist, tugging her forward until their hips are flush. The gasp Catra gives in response sparks something deep in Adora's gut. She begins to kiss Catra with renewed passion, hot and breathless. It's incredibly sloppy - both of them seem too drunk on each other at this point to do much besides pant into each others' mouths. It's nothing like how she kisses Bow. Not even close.

Around them, someone has started up an opposing set of chants. Half of the group chants for Catra, while the other calls for Adora, their cheers mingling into an indecipherable mess of rabid shouting. The energy between the two seems to have carried the entire team along with them. It's totally overwhelming.

And it's in that moment that Adora realizes, quite suddenly, that she wants them to be alone - alone, together. She wants to take Catra behind closed doors and kiss her senseless, again and again, far away from the leering crowd. And as much as she tries to convince herself the desire stems from shyness, a growing force inside her - the one screaming with pleasure at every stroke of Catra's fingers or gentle lave of her tongue - knows better. They are playing a different game now. Adora wants to learn its rules, one by one, until they break her.

She wants Catra to *break* her.

She's grinding against Adora's abdomen now. The denim of her shorts is rough against Adora's soft tee. Adora feels herself falling into a trance, her body tensing and releasing with every slow roll. This is good. This is so, *so* good - better than anything she's ever known. And it's no big step whatsoever to slide her hands onto Catra's bare thighs and push up, up, slowly and steadily, until her thumbs finally edge beneath the cuffs of Catra's shorts. Now she can feel her heat as Catra moves against her, thumbs brushing underwear over thin, hot skin, and Catra is whining into her mouth in a way that sets her body on fire, and if she can just push a *tiny* bit farther she can -

"*Time out!*"

Adora pulls back with a wet *pop*, adrenaline surging through her body. Catra's eyes are glazed; her lips are swollen and slightly parted. Both of them are breathing hard.

"We have reached the official limits of our contest!" Perfuma's voice is shriller than Adora's ever heard it, even on the field. "Round two will be happening in the bedroom! *Privately!*"

There's a groan from the periphery - probably Lonnie. But the rest of the team is staring at them with a look Adora's never seen before. Shock, she guesses - or maybe a little confusion. Like they'd all been woken out of a trance of their own.

Adora realizes quite suddenly that her hands are still in Catra's shorts.

"Right!" she blurts, removing her thumbs like she's been burned. Catra snaps to attention herself, removing her fingers from Adora's hair. "Got it. Haha…sorry."

A nervous chuckle passes through the crowd as Catra slides off Adora's lap. Adora can already feel her face beginning to heat, even as Catra's absence leaves her body cold.

She'd gone too far. She couldn't articulate how, but she knew it - she'd crossed a line. And once again, she has no idea what to do next.

There's a brief, awkward lull in the room as Adora climbs to her feet. She distracts herself by offering a hand to Catra, who's still looking a bit shell-shocked as she accepts. There's a faint blush in her cheeks that's only highlighted by the pinkness of her lips. Adora can't imagine she herself looks any better.

It's almost too much, the silence; it sends Adora's already-racing heart into a frantic rattle against her rib cage. She's a few seconds away from fleeing out the back door and running, all the way to Montana if she has to, just to escape it all.

Fortunately, Lonnie is there. And Lonnie is still extremely drunk.

"That was hot as *shit!*"

The room bursts immediately into nervous giggles as the tension spills over. Adora can't help but grin as she drops her gaze to her feet.

"I told you I was good," she says, a bit too worked up to pull off her cocky facade.

"I stand corrected." Catra seems to have recovered now; her voice is as calm and disaffected as ever. "You northerners really are a different breed. Guess it's all the sexual repression."

That earns a laugh from the group. When Adora turns to meet her eyes, she sees none of her previous fluster. The old charismatic nonchalance is back in full force. It's almost like it never happened.

Adora needs to calm down. Fast.

"We have a guest bedroom down the hall," Perfuma offers. Now that the risk of public indecency has been eliminated, she seems a

little more willing to play ball. “You can lock the door from the inside for, erm…privacy. Unless you’d like to call a truce?”

Adora is terrified to meet Catra’s eyes. She doesn’t want to see the things she’s afraid of most - the discomfort, the suspicion. She feels like everything she’s ever thought or felt is written all over her face for everyone to see. Exposed for the truth of what she is, whatever that may be.

But when she does look up…Catra is smiling. And in an instant, Adora’s anxieties seem to melt away.

“Absolutely fucking not,” Catra says, without hesitation. “Death before dishonor. You?”

Adora thinks she might be grinning a bit too hard when she replies.

“Death before dishonor.”

The room bursts out in cheers once again. Adora feels herself finally begin to relax. Whatever she’s done, it’s not going to end her life. Maybe she can still pass this off as yet another bizarre side effect of her hypercompetitive spirit.

It’s a shame she’s having so much trouble convincing herself.

There are plenty of whoops and pats on the back as she takes Catra’s hand and pulls her gently down the hallway. You’d think they’d just won nationals, by the way everyone was carrying on.

“No cheating, you two!” Mermista jeers. “I want a full summary when you get back.”

Adora feels Catra turning and giving some sort of gesture. “Scout’s Honor.”

Adora smirks. When Catra turns back, she mutters, “Pretty sure the Scouts wouldn’t approve of this.”

She reaches for the doorknob and pushes it open to a dark room. When she looks back, Catra has a sly grin on her face.

"I did a few years of Scouts," she replies, hitting the light switch on her way in. "Trust me. Those summer camps were a lot gayer than you'd think."

She closes the door behind them.

The moment they've shut themselves off from the rest of the group, Adora's heart rockets into her throat. Even the creeping effects of the third beer, only just making their way into her system, can't completely quell the ungodly terror of being sequestered in a room, alone, with *Catra Weaver*. That would be terrifying even if they weren't about to do unspeakable acts on Perfuma's bed.

Catra notices the panic in her eyes. It'd be impossible for her not to. But instead of leaning into it - using it as an intimidation tactic - Adora sees her expression soften.

"Hey." She gives Adora's hand a quick squeeze. "Come sit with me. I promise not to stick my tongue down your throat."

Adora giggles a little at that. She can't help it. "OK."

Catra's smile is warm.

They settle on the edge of the bedspread as Adora tries to get her bearings. The guest room is nice enough - plain, but homey, with a pink knit bedspread Adora's pretty sure is handmade. Her mom's side of the family would probably know exactly what kind of fabric it is, but Adora hadn't inherited that gene. It's all the same to her.

Catra's sitting close, but not abnormally so. Just enough that Adora can feel the warmth of her skin against her own. They've let go of each other's hands; Adora finds herself missing the contact. It kind of scares her.

"We don't have to keep going, you know." Catra's voice is strangely artless. "We can just sit here and make fun of the interior decorating for ten minutes, and then rock-paper-scissors on a winner."

Adora looks at her curiously. She seems to genuinely mean it; there's no trace of mockery in her expression. "What happened to 'death before dishonor'?"

Catra rolls her eyes. They're really pretty. Adora needs to stop thinking about that, probably.

"I just said that to get those losers off our backs," she says dismissively. "But we don't actually have to lose our lesbian virginities in this room right now. No one's gonna know either way."

Adora raises her brows. "You're a lesbian virgin?"

Catra laughs. It's a sweet sound.

"Please. That 'reputation' of mine is total bullshit. I've never actually gotten past second base in one of these things."

It's a pretty big relief, to be honest - more than Adora thought it would be. But somewhere below the surface of her drunken, soupy brain, she sees a red flag waving.

"Why are you being all nice to me?" Adora asks, voice heavy with suspicion. "Think I can't handle the pressure, or something? 'Cause if you think I'm gonna forfeit, you're dead wrong."

Catra chuckles. She scoots backward a bit, then sinks into the bedspread, adjusting until she's laying lengthwise. "Of course not. I want my victory to mean something. And honestly, I'd say you *handled* me pretty well back there, all things considered."

Adora laughs, even as she feels the blood rushing to her face. She leans back to join Catra on the bed; they both keep their gazes

trained on the spackled ceiling. “Thank you. You’re, uh…not so bad yourself.”

Catra hums her amusement.

They lay like that a while. Adora feels comfortable beside her, despite the nervous energy still buzzing between them. If they were somewhere else - doing something else - Adora might curl into her and rest her head on Catra’s shoulder. Count the bumps on the ceiling, and let the buzz of liquor and body heat lull her into a stupor.

But they’re not somewhere else. And when Adora turns to look, Catra has a contemplative look on her face.

“I don’t want to mess things up with your boyfriend,” she admits softly. Her eyes are trained upward. “Not more than I already have. That’s why I asked.”

Adora finds herself turning onto her side to face her, her body curled in a loose ball. She lets her eyes travel lazily over Catra’s face. “He’s not my boyfriend. Not really. And to be honest…you’re not the one who’s gonna mess that up.”

Catra’s brow furrows. She turns her head until they’re looking each other in the eyes; she seems suddenly much closer than she was before.

“What do you mean?”

What *did* she mean? Adora’s not sure; the words had come to her unbidden. She should probably just keep her mouth shut. But the liquor’s making her mind fuzzy. Whatever filter she’d had before entering this room seems to have melted away.

“I think we’re going to end things tomorrow.”

She shouldn’t have said that. Not out loud. It’s such a big, terrifying statement, and it shouldn’t have entered the world like

this. But she can't take it back - and now, Catra's upset. Adora can see it in her eyes.

"Because of me?" Her brow is scrunched with concern. The last thing Adora should be thinking of right now is how cute she looks like that. Her brain is rebelling against her.

"No," Adora says firmly. "Not because of you."

Catra seems to relax at that - a little. "Then why?"

Adora's eyes trail over Catra's face against her will. This close, she can see all the individual hairs of her perfect brows. The light layer of peach fuzz on her cheeks. She thinks she might enjoy the feeling of all these things beneath her lips. Then she thinks she might enjoy never having to think at all anymore, ever again.

Catra's eyes are dark and concerned when she meets them again. She sighs.

"I love him," Adora admits. "So much. I guess that's why I was so sure this would work. But I…I don't feel the way I'm supposed to. And I think he knows."

Catra's eyes flutter shut. Her features look anxious.

"I'm sorry if I made things worse."

Adora is struck, quite suddenly, by the change in her demeanor since they entered the room. She wasn't sure what to expect when they shut that door - besides the obvious - but *gentleness* wasn't anywhere on the list. It's surprising. Somehow, it makes everything feel much more dangerous than before.

But Adora can't seem to stop herself from taking Catra's hand anyways, bringing it to rest lightly on her stomach. Their fingers fit so perfectly together. She wonders why no one else's hand has ever felt quite so natural to hold.

"You didn't," Adora says firmly. "I promise."

Catra's eyes blink open. They settle for a moment on Adora's, looking straight into the heart of her. Then they flicker, undeniably, to her lips.

Adora feels her breath catch.

"You're a good kisser," Catra says simply. Her voice is quiet. "I like playing chicken with you."

Adora swallows as she tries to keep her pulse steady. She's not sure why the statement makes her feel excited and disappointed all at once. "Does this mean you're back on for round two?"

Catra chuckles softly. She finally turns until their bodies are mirroring each other; dangerously close. "I was never off. I just wanted to make sure I wasn't homewrecking first."

Adora's stomach squeezes at that. She fights the urge to glance at Catra's lips as she speaks. "Don't worry. I'm more than capable of wrecking my own home without your help."

Catra laughs, wincing a little in sympathy. Then her arm slides gently over Adora's waist, tugging her close - and Adora feels her mind go quiet.

"Don't think that's gonna make me go easy on you, Grayskull." Her breath tickles Adora's cheek. "I'm still the gay chicken champion. And I'm still gonna kick your ass."

There is so much Adora should be worried about right now. So many potential dangers lurking behind this corner. But right now, with the buzz coursing fully through her system, she can't see them. There is only this warm, pretty girl, and her warm, pretty lips, and the vague sensation that the answers to all her questions lie somewhere in between them.

So instead of saying what she's supposed to say - whatever that is - she places her palm on Catra's cheek, cupping lightly against her jawbone, and whispers, "Good."

She leans in to kiss her before the word has a chance to take hold.

Adora was right. There are answers in these lips, even if she's not quite ready to hear the questions yet. She licks gently into Catra's mouth, letting their tongues graze again and again, and it is the sweetest thing she has ever tasted. Her fingers thread through her short, choppy hair and come to rest against her scalp like they are meant to be there; Catra sighs beneath the warmth of her palms.

When Catra's hands travel under the hem of her shirt, Adora expects another bold movement in their game. Instead, she brings one to rest on Adora's bare waist while the other finds her spine. Her fingers trail languidly up the ridges, then back down again, slow and exploratory. Every lingering touch sends a thrill of sensation through Adora's body; she has to fight the moan that threatens to escape her lips, channeling it as much as she can into their kiss.

Adora's shirt comes off soon after, but it does not feel like strategy. It is simply the next step - a natural evolution she barely questions. Nor is she concerned with gameplay when she slides her hands gently up Catra's torso and finds that she is braless, her chest free and unbound. Of course she will tease the delicate outer skin of Catra's breasts with her fingertips. Of course she will bring her hand to rest in the center of Catra's chest and feel her heart beating, firm and heavy, against her palm. Of course, of course, of course.

She has heard that some people are only lesbians when they drink. That they take pleasure in the company of women while under the spell of intoxication, snapping out of it the moment they're sober. If this is true, Adora thinks that she will drink a lot more often than she did before. She thinks that maybe being an alcoholic would not be so bad, if it meant she was allowed to do things like this.

She has started moaning into Catra's mouth now, just a little. It is gentle enough to be mistaken for simple exhaling, she thinks, and so she keeps doing it. And maybe Catra is having the same thought, because Adora can hear her moaning softly too; louder, every time Adora strokes the skin of her chest with her thumb. Maybe it is just breathing. Maybe it is a figment of Adora's drunken imagination. Or maybe it is just the game. They are still playing, right?

Adora's not sure she cares anymore.

When Catra's shirt comes off, Adora nearly loses on the spot. It is almost impossible not to marvel in the sight - those perfect, dusky nipples, standing erect against a canvas of warm, dark skin. But she cannot lose - losing is stopping, she *will not* stop - and so she contents herself with running her fingertips lightly over the peaks while she mouths a kiss against Catra's jaw.

Something seems to finally break in Catra at that. Her heavy breaths become quiet gasps, her body arcing abruptly into Adora's touch. It makes Adora even bolder with her own want. She begins to kiss her way down Catra's neck, suckling lightly on each bit of exposed skin before releasing it with a gentle pop. With every inch lower, she bites a little bit harder. And with every inch lower, Catra's breathing gets a little bit louder.

By the time Adora makes it to her nipples, they are straining violently in the cool air, and Catra is keening wordlessly beneath her. Her fingers are in Adora's hair now, combing through her waves with one hand while the other begins to curl into a desperate fist. And it collapses the last of Adora's restraint. She loves feeling Catra's hands on such a sensitive part of her body. She loves having Catra's soft skin on her lips. The tastes, and the sounds, and the *feelings* of it all - she loves every second.

She throws caution to the wind and sucks Catra's nipple directly into her mouth.

“Oh my god,” Catra whimpers. She begins to rock against Adora’s hipbone, seeking pressure. “Oh m - *fuck*, Adora.”

And if Catra is still playing the game, Adora thinks she must be the greatest actor on the face of the planet. So it is only right that she responds to that performance with heat of her own, wrapping her arms around Catra’s waist and *yanking* her upwards, pressing their lower bodies as close as they can get while she mouths at the other nipple and suckles her into oblivion.

She thinks she’s going to fuck this girl, now. She has never fucked anyone before, let alone a woman - but Catra is grinding hard against her pelvis, and her fingers are tugging painful bursts of pleasure against her scalp, and Adora cannot imagine a universe where she won’t dip her fingers between this girl’s legs and rub her until she feels good. And if she’d known she was going to love it this much she would’ve never started, but they’re here now, and she’s drunker than she meant to be, and she will end things with Bow tomorrow, she *swears*, and -

BAM BAM BAM

Adora leaps off of Catra at almost the exact time that Catra rolls out from under her, nearly falling off the edge of the bed in her haste. There’s no reason to it - it’s a pure, unadulterated panic response from the depths of Adora’s being. She is on her feet in an instant, panting and wide-eyed and dreading discovery.

A voice calls out from behind the door.

“Adoraaaa.” Lonnie; still shit-faced. “Catraaaa. Catra-doraaaa.”

Adora blinks about five times, trying to clear her stupor.

“You *good*, Lonnie?”

Lonnie snorts.

“Are you done yet?” Her voice is obnoxiously suggestive. “Are y - are you still *kissing*?”

Adora groans, burying her face in her palm. Behind her, Catra speaks up.

"Fuck *off*, Lonnie." Her voice sounds strained, despite its edge. "Go play - fucking Mario Kart, or whatever. Leave us alone."

"I caaaan't." Now she sounds obnoxiously *whiny*. "No one will play with me. They're all just talking about…stuff."

Adora finally risks a glance in Catra's direction. She's seized her shirt off the ground now, pressing it against her chest for modesty. Adora's never seen her so bright-red in her life, even in the middle of practice.

"Lonnie." Catra's voice is deadly calm, on the brink of meltdown. "If you don't go away right now, I'm going to re-rupture your fucking Achilles. And this time, it *will* be a career ender. Got it?"

In the silence that follows, Adora makes the mistake of looking over again. Catra still looks mortified, but she's biting her lip now. When their eyes meet, they are both overcome by a fit of hysterical laughter; they have to fight to suppress it, though not before Adora releases an undignified snort.

"Fiiiiine," they hear Lonnie gripe. "Geez. Enjoy your les-bi-an-ing, I *guess*."

Heavy footsteps pad away from the door; they are alone. Adora feels her laugh die in her chest.

There's a tense silence as they both slip into their shirts, facing away from each other on the bedspread. Adora's anxiety, previously quelled by the beer and the heat of the moment, has roared to life in her chest. The moment prior feels almost like a dream to her; she can't allow herself to consider it for longer than a second. Her mind is completely paralyzed.

Catra isn't saying anything. Adora doesn't dare to look up, but the tension in the room chokes her regardless. She did something

wrong. This was all too much, despite their agreement - and somehow, it is all her fault. She knows it.

"I'm sorry," Adora manages after a moment. Her voice is painfully choked. "I didn't mean to…I'm sorry."

Catra stills behind her. The music continues to pulse behind the door, but the space between them is dead silent. Adora has never felt so sick from nerves in her life.

"Why are you apologizing?" She thinks there's genuine curiosity in Catra's voice, but she honestly doesn't know. Everything is starting to blur.

She closes her eyes.

"I don't know." Adora's voice sounds unbearably small in her own ears. "I don't know. I just am."

Tears - stupid, drunken tears - prick beneath her eyelids. She forces them back.

When she hears Catra padding forward, she thinks she's about to leave. Instead, the bed creaks beside her as the other girl takes a seat. Adora opens her eyes, but keeps them trained on her lap.

"Adora." The voice is soft and kind.

Adora fidgets with the hem of her shorts. She doesn't know how to do this.

"Adora. Look at me."

Finally, she lifts her gaze.

Catra is sad. Adora isn't sure how she knows it, but it's undeniable. She can see it deep in her eyes. She's also smiling a little. Neither of those things are what Adora expected.

A small amount of tension leaves her body.

Catra reaches out to take her hand. Adora is struck again by how small her fingers are, compared to hers. Catra had seemed so larger-than-life before all of this happened. But there's a gentleness in her, too. Adora sees that now.

Catra rubs her thumb once over Adora's in a comforting stroke. Then, before Adora can respond, she leans in and presses a gentle kiss onto her cheek.

Adora's eyes flutter shut. It's a brief, soft moment, over too quickly. When she pulls back, Adora can still feel the ghost of her lips on her skin. She meets Catra's gaze, her brow furrowed with surprise.

"You win," Catra whispers. She gives a small smile that doesn't reach her eyes.

Then, after one more light squeeze of Adora's hand, she stands and heads for the door.

Adora watches her leave without saying a word. The moment the door closes behind her, she's greeted with a flurry of jumbled questions. Adora can hardly make out Catra's response, but her tone is light-hearted. She's already back on.

Adora isn't so quick to recover. She takes a moment to stare at the wallpaper - a subtle rose pattern she hadn't noticed when she came in, given how unobtrusive it was. Her heart beats almost painfully hard in her chest. She can't help but feel that her entire life has changed in the blink of an eye.

But the world awaits. There isn't time to linger - not if she wants to avoid the sort of questions she really can't afford. So Adora takes a deep breath - in for four, hold for four, out for four - and rises from the bed.

She makes sure her mask of victory is well-secured before she opens the door.

. . .

“You don’t understand.”

Adora is sitting on Bow’s living room couch, arms wrapped tight around her stomach. It’s a warm, familiar space, rendered cold by what she’s here to do. A wall clock ticks steadily in the background.

“What don’t I understand?” Bow furrows his brow. “I gave you permission to play gay chicken. You played gay chicken. And now we’re *mutually* deciding to see other people. Still not understanding the ‘horrible betrayal’ part.”

Adora buries her face in her hands. This will be even more difficult than she thought. She is going to have to put things into words she can’t even describe to *herself* yet.

“OK, yes. That’s technically what happened. But it wasn’t…” Adora sighs. “It’s more complicated than that.”

Bow looks at her with genuine confusion. “How?”

Adora just closes her eyes. She knows how. She’s been thinking about it non-stop, from the moment she woke up this morning to the moment she landed on Bow’s doorstep. But saying it out loud feels impossible. She can’t form the words.

Bow misreads her hesitation. His expression softens. “Adora…did everything go OK for you that night? You didn’t feel taken advantage of, did you?”

Something in Adora finally spills over.

“Of course not,” she snaps, before she can stop herself. “Why do you keep asking me if *I’m* OK? I - it doesn’t matter if I’m OK, Bow! I’m the one who fucked up. *I’m* the bad guy!”

“Adora, I literally don’t understand.” Frustration is finally creeping into his tone. “It wasn’t a fuck-up. We weren’t even -“

"I know we weren't official," she interrupts, hysteria rising. "I know that. But you weren't…you're not just some guy I met in a bar, Bow. The only reason we weren't official is because we really wanted it to work. And I knew that, and I still did all that stuff with Catra, even though I *knew* that…"

She trails off. Her heart is pounding too loud to think.

"…Knew what?"

Adora just shakes her head. She's too close to a breakdown to speak.

The silence afterward makes her sick with shame. She can do nothing but bury her face in her hands as her adrenaline fades. She shouldn't have come here - shouldn't have made things worse than they already were. The world really would be better off if she just stopped talking for a while.

She hears Bow take a deep breath.

"OK. So before I start my speech…is there anything else you did with another person, *besides* gay chicken, while we were together?"

Adora has to look up at that. Bow's expression is oddly neutral.

"Of *course* not." She leans forward urgently in her chair. "I would - no. I would never do that without asking."

For some reason, the answer makes him smile.

"OK." Bow looks up at the ceiling fan for a moment, as if gathering his thoughts. Then he meets her gaze again.

"So I think we've both suspected for a while that this, um…hasn't been working out." He winces a little. "Am I right about that?"

After a brief moment, Adora nods.

"Yeah." Her tone turns pleading. "I wanted it to. *So* bad. You have to believe me -"

Bow holds up a hand.

"I know." His eyes are warm as he puts it down. "So did I. But it didn't."

Adora sighs.

"It didn't."

Bow nods. He leans forward a bit on his ottoman, bridging the gap.

"Can I be honest with you?" He gives a small, awkward smile. "When you called…I think a part of me kind of *wanted* you to play."

There is a sudden flow of ice into Adora's gut. She has the faint suspicion that she knows where this is going.

"This talk…was always going to happen," Bow continues. He seems to be choosing his words carefully. "And maybe I should've brought it up sooner, or maybe you should've - who knows. But when you called me last night, all I could really think at the moment was that…this might be good for you. You know what I'm saying?"

And now, there are tears welling in Adora's eyes.

She pauses to take some slow, deep breaths, willing herself to calm down. Bow deserves so much better than a blubbering mess of an apology right now. But she's too overwhelmed with fondness and shame, all at once, to hold herself together.

"I didn't know I was going to feel that way," Adora whispers finally. She wipes quickly at the tears spilling over. "I wouldn't have done it, if I had."

Bow's gaze is overwhelmingly kind.

"Well, *I* had a feeling you would. And I still wanted you to do it," he jokes. "So what does that say about me?"

She can feel her bottom lip starting to tremble; she bites it hard enough to cause pain.

"It means you're an amazing person," she replies, trying and failing to keep her voice steady. "And I really, *really* don't deserve you."

Bow sighs.

"OK, Adora." He drops his head in apparent fatigue, then lifts it. "I can't believe I'm about to tell you this. But if it'll stop you from kicking the crap out of yourself, then I think it'll be worth it."

The curiosity is enough to break through her downward spiral for a moment. She sniffles, then nods.

Bow sighs, long and deep. Then -

"I'm like…kind of, sort of, in love with Glimmer. Just a little bit."

Adora's mouth literally drops open.

"…*What?"*

Bow winces.

"Yeah, it's - I'm sorry. It took a while to figure out." He scratches nervously at the back of his head. "But I've been, uh…pretty certain, for about a week now. So if anyone should be apologizing, it's me. Not you."

Adora blinks. A few tears leak down her face, their cause long forgotten.

"You love Glimmer? Like…*love* love?"

Bow sighs. He hangs his head again. "I'm sorry, Adora. I shouldn't have -"

"*That's great!!"*

Bow's head pops up in surprise.

"What?"

Adora can't keep the smile from spreading across her face.

"Bow, she - OK, she *really* likes you." She can feel herself beginning to gesture excitedly. "Like, you have no idea. She's been acting so weird since we got together, and I could tell last night was hard for her, too -"

"*What?"*

"- and this is amazing!" She grins hard. "You've got to tell her!"

Bow looks like he's been struck by a freight train. His mouth opens, then closes again.

"Adora…" A slow, incredulous grin spreads across his face. "Are you wingmanning me *mid-breakup?*"

The smile drops off of Adora's face. She buries her head in her palms again, groaning.

"Oh my God, I'm *so* sorry -"

Bow is laughing now.

"Shut up, Adora." He can barely speak. "Literally, I - why are we like this?"

Finally, Adora cracks up too.

They laugh for a while, letting the stress of the last few hours drain from their bodies. Adora's a little closer to crying than she'd

like - maybe she *is* crying, at some points - but it's still a welcome relief. She feels lighter when it's done.

But when the energy between them settles, she realizes there is still more to be said. She makes sure her body is as relaxed as it can get, and then speaks.

"Bow, listen." Adora sighs "I messed up. And you could blame the alcohol, or the communication issues, or whatever you want, but I…I still feel like I crossed a line. And I'm sorry."

Bow looks like he wants to interrupt. But to his credit, he manages to hold his tongue. Adora can only hope the message is sinking in.

"I guess I just want to say…thank you." She gives him a sad smile. "I meant what I said, about not deserving you. Glimmer is literally the luckiest girl on Earth."

Bow blushes again at that. He glances at his feet, suddenly shy. "So…how sure *are* you, exactly, about the liking thing? Like, is it just an educated guess, or -"

"Oh my God, Bow, stop being dumb. She is completely obsessed with you. I'm pretty sure she has been since, like, fourth grade." Adora leans forward and shakes his shoulders for emphasis. "Go - call - her. Right now."

"Alright, alright!" Bow laughs, holding up his hands in surrender. "Geez!"

Adora relents, still smiling. After a moment, she rises from the couch.

"I will leave you alone now, because I'm pretty sure Glimmer already hates me enough." She lifts her eyebrows dramatically. "But go call her, the second I leave, and tell her you love her. And then go cuddle with her. Because she is probably *really* hungover right now."

Bow laughs, still a bit flustered. But after a moment, he nods.

“OK. I will.”

Adora heads for the screen door, chuckling quietly to herself. She’s never felt such a strange mixture of emotions swirling in her body at once - it makes her want to crash on her couch and nap for twelve hours. But she thinks there’s a kernel of hope beneath it all. And that’s more than she thought she’d be able to say when she got here.

Right when her fingers hit the handle, Bow speaks.

“Adora?”

She turns. Bow’s expression is serious, but determined.

“Don’t be a stranger,” he says finally. “I mean that.”

Adora loves him. It’s so easy to see, now that she isn’t bogged down with all the rest. But it’s not the right time to say it. She hopes that day will come soon.

Instead, she just nods.

“I won’t. Promise.”

Bow smiles. Then he turns - towards the phone on his end table, she can’t help but notice - and Adora pushes through the door.

She feels closer to herself, in that moment, than she’s ever been before

Chapter End Notes

> do not - I repeat, DO NOT - listen to either Enya or 90’s slow jams while reading this fic. it will traumatize you as it has me

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It takes about a month for her and Catra to start talking again.

They avoid each other after the party. There's no animosity between them - they function fine together on the field, if not better than before. But there's nothing they can say to each other that feels safe, and so they end up saying nothing at all. They drift into their respective social groups while winter turns to spring, and the season winds to a close.

Adora watches her a lot, though. She can't really help it. She must get chewed out at least once a week by Coach Huntara for being "up in the clouds" during practice. Adora's not in the clouds, though - she's following Catra around the field, watching her tear her opponents to shreds, and remembering how it felt to have that strong, powerful girl lying next to her in bed. To feel her soften beneath her fingertips; kiss her sweetly, and plead for more.

Her save record's probably not as optimal as it could be by the time state regionals roll around.

It seems inevitable that their lives will go in different directions after the season ends. Adora starts hearing back from colleges - a bittersweet experience, given that she can't afford most of the ones she applied to. A few schools are offering soccer scholarships, but none are full-ride, and her parents have already made it clear she's not getting any money from them. Try as she might, the math just doesn't seem to work.

She decides to knock her gen-ed out at a local JC and apply again when she's a junior. It's far from glamorous, but she knows it's the best choice she has. It'll give her time to build up a savings, and in the end, a degree is a degree. Prestige can wait.

Catra's doing away with college all-together. That's the rumor, at least - Adora doesn't have the guts to ask directly. Apparently, she's starting an apprenticeship with one of the local tattoo artists in town. Adora hadn't realized Catra even did art in the first place, but it doesn't surprise her much. She seems like the type.

Sometimes - when Adora is tired, or tipsy, or otherwise freed from those nagging voices of self-recrimination in her head - she wonders how it would feel to tackle adulthood with Catra by her side. They could get a tiny apartment together, somewhere in the arts district; carpool to work and school. Adora would learn to cook shitty college staples so that she could force Catra to eat when she got home, and Catra would tease her over the lack of seasoning. But they'd grab a bowl anyways and sit in front of the TV, making fun of whatever stupid program was on while they chatted about their day. Maybe they'd wind up in each other's arms by the end of it. Somehow, the idea of holding Catra until they both fell asleep was almost as exciting as anything else they could possibly do.

She works her way into Adora's dreams a lot, that month. Most of them are pretty X-rated, if she's being honest - but not all of them are. One night, she dreams that she's lying topless on the floor of Perfuma's living room while Catra trails over her skin with body paint. They don't talk while it happens, but it's not an awkward thing; Adora feels safe with her. And though she never sees the end result, she knows, somehow, that Catra has transformed her skin into something beautiful. More beautiful than it could ever be on its own.

She wakes up with a dry mouth and a deep, sick longing in her chest.

But she doesn't do anything. She doesn't even try. It feels like the least of what she deserves after what happened - even though Bow and Glimmer are deliriously happy now, Bow having sworn up and down that the whole thing was "water under the bridge". She can't take her choices back, but she can make sure they don't continue forward. So she does. The whole thing would probably

have gone up in smoke anyways, she tells herself. Catra was too good to be real.

And then - divine intervention.

If it had been any other class, this wouldn't have happened. Any other combination of circumstances. But no. Adora is assigned a massive final project worth a quarter of her grade - a *partner* project - in AP Lit. Which just so happens to be a class she shares with Catra, and absolutely no one else she knows.

Adora thinks her brains are going to explode all over the wall the moment it's announced.

But they don't. Not outwardly, at least. And really, it's not *that* big of a deal. There's a bit of awkward tittering at first - mostly on her end - but they ease into things pretty quickly. They're teammates, after all. That kind of bond doesn't just disappear overnight (no matter how *eventful* the night in question happens to be.)

The project is on Shakespeare. Each pairing is randomly assigned a play; theirs is *Much Ado About Nothing.* They're tasked with compiling a summary, a rhetorical analysis, a narrative analysis, and about a thousand other different analyses, then plastering them all on one of those giant poster boards they use for science fairs. On top of it all, they have to finish with a three-minute recitation of "a scene of their choice." It's insanely comprehensive - enough for their teacher to dedicate the bulk of their lesson time to completing it.

Adora winds up spending a lot of time with Catra, those last few months.

They do their best to keep things productive. The project is massive, after all - there's not nearly enough time left in the year to complete it. But Adora finds that she's alarmingly content to let the minutes slip by when Catra's around. Because really, how could some dumb poster board possibly compete? How could *anything?*

Catra is everything Adora thought she was, going into the season - gorgeous, charming, cooler than Adora by a factor of a million. But she's *more* than that, too. She leaves dumb doodles on the corners of Adora's notebooks when she isn't paying attention. She teases Adora until she blushes, and then gets grouchy and flustered the moment Adora returns the favor. And beneath all of that, she's just…sweet. Funny, brave, and totally sweet.

Adora falls so hard she nearly breaks.

There are things they don't discuss. The party is the most obvious one - neither of them seem willing to cross that boundary, even though Adora finds herself wishing, more and more, that they would. But they keep family off the table, too. For Adora, it's just a lack of will to explain things - her parents are married and financially stable, so she'd never really been able to convey why things feel as wrong as they do. But Adora suspects that Catra's issues run pretty deep. There are a few too many bitter jokes about CPS and absentee mothers littered in their conversations for coincidence.

Catra never brings it up, though. And neither does she. Instead, they giggle over Shakespeare's pervy double entendres, and make origami claws out of binder paper. Adora makes sure to compliment Catra on everything she can imagine - her style, her drawings, her humor, how gorgeous her eyes look in the light. Partly, she does it to make sure Catra knows that someone values her. But mostly, she does it because she means it.

By the time end of term rolls around, Adora struggles to remember how it felt to live in a world that didn't have Catra so close to its center. Maybe they'll never get the chance to know each other the way they had before - Adora is close to making peace with that. But the knowledge she has received in the aftermath is more precious to her than anything physical could ever be. It amazes her now that she'd explored this girl's body without any idea of the beautiful soul living inside it.

Their final month of high school arrives before Adora has time to blink. Goodbyes are said; long-term plans are revealed and changed. And Adora and Catra are friends. She thinks they might just stay that way for a long time to come.

For a while, Adora convinces herself not to wish for more.

. . .

They stumble into the plan almost by accident.

In a reference to their long-standing inside joke about hanging a portrait of William Shakespeare on their bedroom walls to pray to every night (long story) Catra casually mentions that her wall is too crowded for it to fit. When Adora compromises, suggesting she hang a wallet-sized photo instead, Catra claims it *still* wouldn't fit.

Naturally, Adora has her doubts.

"*Everyone* has four inches of space somewhere on their wall, Catra," she claims. "You're just not trying hard enough."

Catra rolls her eyes. "I'm not *everyone*. I'm me. And I'm telling you, I don't have four inches. I probably wouldn't even have one."

Adora crossed her arms with disbelief. "No way. You're bluffing."

Catra throws her hands in the air. "I dunno what you want me to say. I mean, do you want to see it?"

"Yeah."

Catra blinks in surprise. Adora does too, once she processes what she's said.

And that's how they agree to finish up their project at Catra's house.

They settle on the following evening. Adora genuinely can't believe her luck - she's so convinced it's all a joke that she refuses to mention it again after they've decided, for fear that Catra will change her mind. But she doesn't. And eventually, the allotted time rolls around, and Adora finally allows herself to accept that she's going to hang out with Catra Weaver - *in her room.* It's almost more gleeful anticipation than she can bear.

She drives herself there around four, after she's had time to wash up. Catra hadn't given her much information beyond the address - only that it was a cream-colored house, and her mom wouldn't be around. She's not surprised to find that the house is in a rougher neighborhood. It's one of those prefab homes on wheels; ones her mom used to scoff at and call "eye sores" when they drove past them in town.

Catra had kept up a neutral facade before Adora arrived, but Adora can tell she's defensive when she lets her in. There's a lot of needless apologizing, and self-deprecating jokes that feel a little close to home. Adora gently brushes them off; she wants to see the room. Whatever's waiting for her in there, she has a feeling it's going to blow her mind.

"…Holy *shit."*

And she's right.

Posters. Wall-to-wall, seam to seam, and tons of overlap. Almost all of them are music-related. Adora can recognize a few basics - Nirvana, Guns N' Roses, Van Halen - but most of them are foreign to her. It's immediately clear that Catra was right. There is not an inch of space left.

Catra leans against the doorframe while Adora gawks. After a long moment, she speaks.

"Told you. No room for Willy here."

Adora pulls her eyes away from the walls for a moment to focus in on Catra. She's got this strange little smile on her face; her

expression seems to be vacillating between pride and embarrassment.

“I had no idea you were so into music,” Adora says, still a bit shellshocked. “I - you never told me.”

Catra shrugs.

“Not like we had a lot of chances to bust out the Walkman during AP Lit,” she says nonchalantly. “But yeah. Kind of an audiophile.”

Adora glances upward. Even the ceiling is totally covered. It must get super dark in here at night.

“You know, sometimes you almost have me convinced that you’re a normal loser like the rest of us.” Adora shakes her head with wonder. “And then you show me something like this, and I remember you’re literally the coolest, most badass human being on the face of the planet.”

That has the desired effect; Catra immediately looks down at the floor, biting her lips as her cheeks flush crimson. “Shut up. You’re such a sap.”

Adora’s blushing too, now. But she smiles, letting her eyes drift towards the wall once again. “You bring it out in me.”

When she looks back, there’s a depth to Catra’s stare that makes Adora shiver.

They hold eye contact as long as Adora can bear - which is not as long as she really wants to. Then she clears her throat and lets her gaze shoot to the floor.

She hears Catra shuffling behind her, a bit awkwardly. “How’s the project board going?”

That makes Adora perk up. She meets Catra’s eyes again with an excited grin.

"*Really* good." She takes a seat on the edge of Catra's dark grey comforter, sloughing off her jacket as she does. "Everything's pretty much finished. I just need to add the trim and let it set overnight, but the analyses are all printed out. I ended up going with the plaid theme - I hope that's OK."

Catra laughs. She steps forward, then moves to take a seat at Adora's side. "It's fine, dork. I can't believe you agreed to do all of that on your own. You're insane."

"*You're* insane," Adora replies incredulously. She turns to hang her jacket on Catra's bedpost, shaking her head. "I can't believe you didn't want to do it! Assembling the board is literally the best part."

Catra scoffs. "Think I missed out on whatever weird, neurotic gene of yours makes gluing paper onto cardboard seem fun."

Adora gives her a gentle, teasing nudge with her shoulder; they're still touching when their bodies settle. "It is *not* weird. Seriously, aren't you supposed to be an artist?"

Catra chuckles. Then she leans back onto the comforter, scooting to the far side of the bed. "Not that kind."

When she pats the space beside her, Adora's heart leaps.

She has to fight to keep the smile off her face as she settles at Catra's side. It's impossible for her mind not to drift to the last time they'd shared a bed this way. She's been getting better about putting stuff like that out of her head, but the warmth of Catra's body beside her brings it all surging back. She's just grateful Catra can't hear her heart beating.

"When do you start the apprenticeship?" Adora asks - mostly just for something to break the silence.

"After graduation." She sounds a bit disappointed. "Netossa wanted me to 'focus on school' these last few weeks. Like it even matters, at this point."

Adora hums. “She seems cool.”

Catra chuckles.

“Yeah, she is.” She smiles. “There’s a studio upstairs from the shop. She can’t afford to pay me much, but she says I can live there for free once I get started. So assuming I get approved for food stamps, I’m basically gonna have zero bills.”

Adora grins. She can’t help but shuffle a bit closer in her excitement. “That’s awesome! I’m so happy you found this opportunity!”

“Yeah,” Catra laughs. “Me too. Honestly, I really lucked out with Netossa. It’s almost like having a mom.”

Adora laughs before she’s processed what’s been said. Then, her smile fades.

They both stare at the ceiling a minute. Adora yearns to say something - to break the silence - but nothing feels right. She doesn’t want to address it if Catra isn’t ready, but doesn’t want to change the subject if she is.

“I’m kind of a sob story, to be honest.”

Adora turns her head.

Catra is looking up at the ceiling. All of her enthusiasm from earlier has vanished. She just looks tired now.

“Figured the fact that I live in a double-wide was probably clue enough.” She shrugs. “But yeah. I’m sort of a massive downer.”

Adora is flooded with a sudden wave of deep remorse. Everything she can think to say feels like too much for this moment, but she yearns to say it regardless.

“You don’t have to talk about it if you don’t want to,” she finally replies. “I want to hear it, but like…don’t feel obligated, just for

my sake."

Catra chuckles bitterly. She keeps her gaze pointed firmly at the ceiling.

"If I didn't want you knowing my tragic backstory, I wouldn't have brought you here," she remarks drily. "You're…I trust you. You're good."

Adora sighs. She turns her head back to the ceiling to give Catra space. There's an old Sinéad O'Connor poster hanging directly above their heads; she focuses on it as Catra speaks.

"I don't really have a mom." She scoffs. "I mean, I *literally* don't have a dad, but Mom's an alcoholic. So…same thing, really."

Adora nods. It's what she suspected, but it doesn't make it any more tolerable to hear. She's overcome with the sudden, overwhelming desire to hold Catra close - even though she knows it's not what Catra wants.

"What time does she usually get back?" Adora asks softly.

There's a brief pause. Catra exhales slowly beside her.

"More like, 'what day', to be honest."

Adora's heart sinks even lower.

"Haven't seen here in a while," Catra says. Her voice is overly casual. "She'll go on benders and stumble in at, like, four AM. By the time I get home from school, she's usually gone again."

Adora is overwhelmed with a sudden, blinding anger. She hopes she never sees this woman in person; Adora's not sure she'll be able to control herself. She would have to be out of her mind to not see how lucky she was to have Catra as a daughter.

"I'm sorry," Adora finally says. Her voice is low with regret.

Catra sighs.

"Don't be." She scoffs. "Trust me. It's way better than when she actually used to *talk* to me. That shit was a nightmare."

The sentiment sparks something deep and familiar in Adora's gut. She shouldn't say anything; shouldn't even try to compare. But the words are out of her mouth before she can stop them.

"I don't talk to my parents either."

Adora feels, rather than sees, Catra turn her head to look. She hurries on.

"It's not the same - like, not even remotely. I'd never imply it was." She fidgets on the bedspread a bit. "We just…don't really have the same schedules. Mom works overnights at the ER. And Dad's this, like, super talented computer engineer, and he's on call a lot. So our schedules just don't really overlap."

Catra seems to shuffle a bit closer. Her head turns back to the ceiling. "When's the last time you saw them?"

Adora shrugs. But her voice is a little too high when it comes out. "About a week, I think. Maybe a bit less."

There's a long, heavy silence.

"I'm sorry." Catra exhales quietly through her nose. "That's fucked."

Adora just shrugs. There's a strange, sick feeling in her chest.

"It's fine. Really. It's kind of like you said - I, uh, enjoy being alone more than having to talk to them, if that makes sense." She narrows in on a peeling corner of the Sinéad O'Connor poster. "I think we just sort of mutually decided, way before we moved, that it was better that way, you know? We're so different from each other - like, politically, and ideologically, and stuff - and…I don't

know. I think we just agreed without talking about it to go our separate ways."

Catra doesn't respond right away. The sickness in Adora's chest spreads to her stomach. She feels stupid. Stupid and annoying and alone.

"Parents aren't supposed to divorce you, Adora."

There are tears prickling at Adora's eyes. She blinks rapidly, hoping Catra isn't watching out of the corner of her eyes.

"Yeah, it was pretty fucked up," she says, her laugh a bit unnatural. She swallows back the knot in her throat. "I'm OK, though. I'm an adult now anyways, so it's…whatever. Plus, I've never had to worry about money, or safety, or any of that stuff. So I'm super lucky."

She never should've brought this up. Never should've implied, even indirectly, that her problems paralleled Catra's own. Now she's made everything awkward. When is she going to learn to stop being such an asshole?

Warm fingers slip between her own.

Adora feels a stirring heat spread in her gut. Neither of them look at each other; only the tips of their fingers are laced. Somehow, in spite of everything they'd already done, the simple gesture is overwhelming.

"Where are you gonna go after graduation, Adora?" Her voice is impossibly gentle.

Adora swallows. She slides her palm until it is flush against Catra's. The contact stills her mind.

"They aren't going to help me with college." Her voice trembles slightly; she feels weak. "I'm going to have to find a job soon. Figure out where to live."

She feels Catra's thumb trail up and down her own. Her eyes fall shut.

"You can come to my place if you need," Catra murmurs. "No matter what. You know that, right?"

Adora gives her hand a squeeze. Her fingers are so tiny between her own. She loves the feeling.

"I know." Finally, she turns her head towards Catra. "Thanks."

Catra turns her own head. Suddenly, they are very close. Catra's gaze is soft. Serious.

"Of course."

It is exactly like before. If Adora was drunk, like the last time, she knows what would happen next. But she isn't. And the gap between them is charged with enough electricity to make Adora hesitate.

She lets her thumb trail downward, stilling right over Catra's pulse point. After a moment, she feels it coming, a tiny, rapid blip against her finger. Fast, for an athlete. Catra's eyes widen almost imperceptibly - but she doesn't move. Neither of them do.

Just as Adora is considering letting her gaze drop to Catra's lips, Catra sits up.

The sudden cold at her side is jarring. Catra shuffles to the edge of the bed, a bit too quickly to be natural.

"Sorry for bringing the mood down. We should probably start, uh, waxing poetic now, or whatever."

Their fingers are still clasped. That's the only thing that keeps Adora's mood from plummeting. Adora gives Catra's another squeeze before releasing them.

"Yeah," she says, her laugh a bit nervous. She sits up a little, then clears her throat. "So whatcha thinking for scenes, Benedict?"

Catra spins around so fast it startles her.

"*Benedict?"* She makes a scandalized noise in her throat. "Bullshit. *You're* Benedict. I'm Beatrice."

Now it's Adora's turn to sputter with indignation. "I - *what?* We already agreed on this earlier. I'm a way better fit."

"We agreed that you look like someone who would be *named* Beatrice. Which was intended as an insult. But I am clearly the Beatrice of this duo."

Adora crosses her arms. "So, what? You're saying I'm dumber than you?"

Catra just looks her up and down, a smug expression on her face. It incenses Adora enough to swing one of her own pillows at her head.

"I - *hey!"* she laughs, shoving it back towards Adora. "I didn't even say anything."

"You didn't have to," Adora grumbles. After a moment, she sighs and drops back to the bed. "OK. Convince me, then. Why *are* you the Beatrice of this duo?"

Catra immediately adopts an aire of false poise. She clears her throat, then settles with her hands clasped neatly behind her back.

"I'm so glad you asked." She lifts her hand into the air, beginning to count on her fingers. "One - I'm super mean. Like, a total grade-A bitch. Two - I'm a bastard." She hesitates. "As in, *literally.* Though I'm also a normal bastard. See item one."

Adora giggles. She can't help it. Catra's cute when she puts on a show.

"And *three…"* Catra gestures dramatically, then continues. "I already memorized, like, a bunch of her lines. So you kind of have to give it to me."

Adora scoffs.

"You're bluffing. There's no way that *you* did classwork in advance. You can barely get it done on time in the first place."

Catra's eyes glint; she looks like she wants to clap back. But after a moment, she appears to rein herself in. She clears her throat dramatically, presses her hand to her heart, and begins.

"What fire is in mine ears? Can this be true?

Stand I condemn'd for pride and scorn so much?"

Adora's jaw drops open. Another giggle escapes her mouth; she slaps a hand over it to stop it. Catra's good. Like, *really good* - and completely off-book. Adora can hardly believe her own ears.

"You're joking," she giggles, voice muffled.

Catra ignores her and continues, gesturing firmly towards some invisible force beside her.

"Contempt, farewell! And maiden pride, ***adieu!***

No glory lives behind the back of such."

Adora is laughing full-on now; she can't stop herself. Watching this grimy little punk girl recite Shakespeare with such unbridled passion is simultaneously the strangest and most attractive thing she's ever seen in her life. It makes her face flush bright red just from watching.

Catra seemed to notice - or maybe it's just the part of the speech. Either way, she turns her attention fully to Adora, placing a hand on her shoulder and gesturing to her in a fit of melodrama.

"And, Benedick, love on; I will requite thee!

Taming my wild heart to thy loving hand:

If thou - argh!"

Adora has pulled Catra forward onto the bed, catching her completely off guard. Giddiness has overwhelmed her now, and it seems to be infecting Catra too; she's giggling as she pins Adora onto the mattress, earning a terrified shriek.

"If thou dost love, my k - my kindness shall incite thee

To bind our loves up in a holy band."

Adora has lost all semblance of control. She grabs Catra and tugs her close, shrieking with laughter, but Catra refuses to be halted. Her final lines are basically just her screaming in Adora's ear.

" ***For others say thou dost deserve, and I***

Believe it better than reportingly! "

Finally, Catra collapses on top of Adora, both of them cackling like idiots.

It takes Adora a moment to realize what's happened - she's too lost in her own hysteria at first. But slowly, as their laughter subsided, the warmth of Catra's body begins to sink in. She realizes how heavy Catra is on top of her. How much of their bare skin is touching.

Adora's breathlessness takes on a new urgency. Her lips are only inches away from Catra's ear; she can feel both of their hearts beating against her chest. Instinct overwhelms her every thought.

Before she can second guess herself, she wraps Catra in a warm, tight hug.

She feels Catra's breathing still; it sends a pulse of anxiety down her spine. But seconds later, Catra is returning her embrace. And then they're *really* hugging - hands threading in each others hair, faces pressing into necks. Holding on to each other like they're afraid the other will disappear if they let go.

But Adora doesn't. Instead, as they settle into each other's arms, she exhales slowly through her nose, letting the tension drain from her body as she does. Catra's scent is all around her, her nose smushed a little against Adora's collarbone. It makes her so strangely happy she can't even find words to describe it.

After a moment, she feels Catra beginning to stroke lightly against the back of her head with her thumb. A shiver passes through her body; she quickly mirrors the gesture on Catra's scalp, and is rewarded with a sigh of her own. They lose themselves a while in the simple, repetitive movements. Adora thinks of nothing.

And then Catra is pulling back - just barely. Her skin brushes the covers as she settles a few centimeters away from Adora's face. The tips of their noses brush, ever so slightly.

When Adora opens her eyes, Catra is impossibly close. She is torn between focusing on the pink softness of her lips and those big, gorgeous eyes. Both are transfixing. Her mind is melting more and more with every passing second.

"Rematch?" Catra breathes. She wets the inside of her lips with the tip of her tongue. There's a nervous hesitancy in her eyes.

Adora's pulse is skyrocketing now; she can hardly stand the sense of urgency, the anticipation. But she doesn't lean forward. Instead, she lowers her hand from Catra's scalp, and brings it to rest on her face.

One by one, Adora's fingertips ghost over her features. Her cheekbones. Her jaw. The lines of her brow; the bridge of her nose. Catra's eyes widen as she moves. Her gaze locks onto Adora's face, softening with every touch.

Finally, she moves to cup Catra's cheek with her palm. Her eyes fall to her lips.

"No," Adora murmurs.

Catra's brow furrows with confusion. But Adora doesn't give herself time to be misunderstood.

She leans in.

Kissing Catra is a thing of beauty on its own, but kissing Catra sober is borderline spiritual. She is fully present for every soft press of their lips, which are quickly wet and open against the gentle movement of their tongues. Catra is trembling; her breaths are heavy as she captures Adora's mouth with her own, again and again, hot, needy kisses that leave Adora breathless and desperate for more.

None of them know what to do with their hands. It is nothing like last time, a coordinated performance with a clear linear progression. Now, they are restless, touching each other all over with shaky reverence - cheeks, temples, collarbones. Into every touch, Adora channels the same desperate message; *this is not a game. We are doing this together, and you are so perfect, and this is* ***not*** *a game.*

Eventually, Adora just wraps her arms snug around Catra's body and holds her as they kiss. Catra exhales sharply, then responds by shifting lower, leaving small, clumsy kisses on Adora's neck and jaw. Adora can only cling onto her for dear life as she moves down; her hand slides up the back of Catras shirt, hiking the fabric upward and exposing bare skin.

When Catra begins sucking, hard, on Adora's collarbone, she can't help the choked cry that escapes her lips. This only encourages Catra more. Before long, she has left a trail of wet, aching love bites along the top side of her chest, and her hip bone is pressing firmly between her legs, and something in Adora breaks.

She tears Catra's shirt upward, exposing her breasts; seconds later, Catra is helping her, dragging it up and off her arms and tossing it to the side. There is no time for Adora to appreciate Catra with her eyes, and so she does so with her mouth, kissing feverishly over every bit of soft, exposed skin she finds. Catra's breaths turn to whines; Adora feels her kissing the top of her head over and over, running her hands through her hair with mounting desperation.

A hand reaches down to pull at Adora's own shirt, and she surrenders, letting Catra tug the fabric off of her torso. But seconds later, she feels hesitant fingers running beneath her bra strap, and her heart skips a beat.

"Can I?" Catra pants. Her voice is tentative, even with the quiet hunger running beneath. "Can I see you? Please?"

Adora would never dream of saying no to her.

It's a bit awkward. Adora's sports top is tight; it has to be, with the size of her chest. But eventually, with Catra's help, she manages to wiggle out of it. Her breasts spill forward as Catra discards the bra somewhere off to the side.

And now…Catra is silent. Her eyes rake over Adora's body with a startling intensity as Adora lays there, fighting to keep her insecurity down. No one has ever seen her like this. Not for this long. Maybe there's something wrong with her; something she didn't know about.

Catra brings her hand to Adora's chest. She begins to trace - lightly, with the pads of her fingertips. Adora closes her eyes as Catra trails her fingers over the skin, shuddering as she reaches the crest of her nipple.

"Beautiful," she whispers. Her hand cups around one of her breasts; Adora thinks she might be shaking. "You're so beautiful. You're perfect."

Before Adora can react, Catra pulls her close.

Adora is overwhelmed by her again - her scent, her warmth, the soft compression of their chests. Catra wraps her arms around Adora's waist and buries her face in her neck. Adora cups the back of her head in response, cradling her.

She wasn't expecting this. Being held so gently, out of nowhere. It opens up a deep, aching hole in the center of her chest. She can do little more than press sweet, featherlight kisses against Catra's ear, overcome.

They stay like that for a moment, catching their breath. Adora doesn't ask why. She just rubs the back of Catra's head with her thumb, in easy, repetitive movements. Lets her come back down to Earth.

When Catra pulls back, Adora resists the urge to kiss her lips again. Instead, she brings her hand forward to stroke Catra's cheek. Catra's eyes fall shut.

"Sorry," she mumbles. She leans into Adora's hand. "Got overwhelmed, I think. I don't really know what I'm doing, and you're just…"

Catra exhales.

"Pretty."

Adora's heart sings.

She brings her thumb across Catra's bottom lip, just to feel its fullness against her fingers. Catra purses her lips to gently kiss her skin. It makes her whole hand tingle with warmth.

"I don't know what I'm doing either." She chuckles nervously. "But you already knew that."

Catra smiles. "Could've fooled me, if I'm being honest. You were pretty intimidating that night. Definitely playing to win."

Adora giggles. Her fingers trail along Catra's face, gently exploring. She's not sure she'll ever get enough.

"I wasn't doing it to win," Adora admits. "Not once we got to the bedroom. Like, no matter what, if Lonnie hadn't interrupted, I think I would've…"

She trails off. Catra's eyes fix on her face; something in them darkens.

As Adora watches, she turns her head into Adora's hand, nuzzling with her nose. Then she presses a soft, open-mouthed kiss against the center of her palm.

Adora feels a current travel down her arm.

"I've been thinking about it a lot," Catra murmurs. "Being with you. I have been ever since that night."

She begins to kiss up Adora's fingers now; Adora brings her other hand to slide up the curve of Catra's face, her fingers tangling in Catra's short, choppy waves.

"So have I." Adora's breathing hard again; her voice is rough with overwhelm. "I think about you all the time. You…you have no idea."

When Catra's mouth finds the tip of Adora's index finger, Adora surprises herself by pressing forward in a gentle request. Catra's lips part immediately to admit her; Adora's mind goes completely silent as Catra takes her deep into her mouth, suckling gently against her skin.

When she releases Adora's finger with a gentle pop, Adora realizes she's wet through her underwear. A heady rush flows through her system. She can hardly control her breathing as Catra speaks.

"What do you want, Adora?" She presses her lips against Adora's palm again, then begins to mouth hot kisses down Adora's arm. "Tell me."

Adora exhales. Her fingers tighten in Catra's hair, earning a breathy groan as she works her way down. The sight of her is too perfect for words.

"I just want to make you feel good." She breathes as Catra's mouth latches onto the base of her forearm, sucking a mark onto her skin. Her voice is undeniably wobbly now. "I - I want you to show me."

Catra releases her arm. After a moment, she plants a kiss onto the area and holds it, as if to sooth it. Then she works her way, slowly, back up to Adora's eye level. Her gaze is heavy as she pulls Adora's fist close, pressing another soft kiss onto her knuckles.

"OK, baby." She cups Adora's chin with her hand. "OK. I will."

Catra pulls her close.

Their kiss is slow and easy, this time; unrushed. Catra seems content with just tasting Adora, letting their tongues graze against each other, and soon Adora finds herself falling under the same hypnotic spell. It is so much better, doing this sober. Any anxiety she has is worth the fullness of Catra's presence.

After a while, Catra breaks their contact - only to plant a few more soft kisses on her cheeks, her brow, even her eyelids. Adora is left dazed. Nobody's ever paid her such gentle attention in her life. It's almost too much.

But finally, Catra pulls away, and Adora realizes she is turning around. Catra presses closer until they are lying with her back to Adora's front, facing the side wall. Adora wraps her arms around Catra's waist and pulls her close, even as a part of her is confused about the shift.

She isn't confused for long. After a moment, she feels Catra's hand slide over hers on her waist, threading their fingers. Catra waits a moment, then pushes their hands gently towards the waistband of her shorts - and then, Adora understands.

“Oh.” Adora begins stroking into the ball of Catra’s hip; her stomach heats when she twitches forward, almost imperceptibly. “Can you show me? What to do?”

Catra doesn’t respond; she just leans back further into Adora, their bodies sealing against one another. And then, Catra dips their fingers past her shorts, beneath her underwear, and into her heat.

They both exhale at the contact. Catra is so wet; she sighs as Adora runs her fingertips lightly beneath her vulva, glancing over her entrance. Adora’s mind shuts down completely. It’s way too good, this feeling. She can’t believe it’s even allowed.

Fortunately, Catra is in control. After letting Adora touch for a moment, she slides her fingers upward, onto her clit. Adora feels a breath of air leave her lungs.

“Make a V with your fingers.” She spreads Adora’s fingertips. “Like that. And work up and down.”

Adora begins to obey. She feels Catra’s breath still. “Like this?”

“Mhm.” Her voice is a bit choked. “Just…a little bit harder. You’re - you’re doing good.”

Adora exhales softly into Catra’s ear at the praise. She begins rubbing rhythmically against her mound.

“Good?” She can feel Catra tensing against her. She thinks it’s a good sign, but she has to make sure.

She’s right. Catra backs up against her, seeking closeness. “Good. That’s - you’re -“ She suddenly removes her hand from Adora’s and brings it to grip her forearm, exhaling sharply. “*Please.”*

Instinct takes over.

She moves forward to hold Catra as close as she can, mouthing at her neck while she works Catra over. Already, Catra’s breathing is

ragged. It sends Adora into a haze right alongside her.

"You're so beautiful," she whispers. Catra moans softly at the words. "*So* beautiful."

Catra begins to roll with Adora's movements now. Her hands grasp blindly behind her, reaching Adora's face. Adora lets one of Catra's fingers slip into her own mouth, sucking hard, and groans when she tastes the liquid heat on her skin.

"Fuck," she pants, once the finger has left her mouth. Catra's hand finds the back of her neck now and grips tight; she's begun moving in earnest against Adora's fingers. "You're amazing, Catra. I hope you know how perfect you are. I hope someone's told you."

And for some reason, that is the thing that seems to break her. Catra's cry is anguished enough to make Adora afraid - but then she's falling apart in Adora's arms, gripping her tight enough to hurt as her hips jerk forward, and Adora forgets everything else.

"You're so gorgeous." She's babbling now, like it's her approaching the edge, and not Catra. "God, you - you're so incredible. You're doing such a good job."

It's nonsense, even as she means every word. But it seems to have a powerful effect on Catra. Her hips are jerking in tiny, desperate thrusts; Adora can tell she's dangerously close.

"Beautiful," Adora whispers. She's not even making sense anymore; the flood of endorphins has turned her into a broken record. "Beautiful. Beautiful, beautiful girl."

Catra cries out, burying her nails in Adora's shoulder, and comes.

Everything courses through Adora at once - the pain, the adrenaline, and the ecstasy of feeling Catra peak beneath her fingers. She rubs Catra to the edge of her climax, then stills, letting Catra chase the aftershocks against her hand. Her grip on

Adora's shoulder gradually loosens; she feels a sweet relief course through her as her nails slide free from her skin.

Her work between Catra's legs complete, Adora finally allows her hand to drift upward. She lightly explores Catra's torso, leaving wet trails along her skin. Her fingers glance over Catra's breasts, brushing lightly over the nipple. Eventually, she brings her hand to rest over Catra's pounding heart.

She is not surprised when Catra claims her hand and brings it to her mouth, sucking her own slick off of Adora's fingers. The movement is slow, this time - she is already satisfied. It doesn't stop the heat from coursing between Adora's own legs.

Finally, they still. The room is warmer now from their activity; Adora can feel it against her skin. Their breathing is heavy but quiet as they settle into the sheets.

Eventually, Catra breaks the silence.

"I totally ripped your skin off just now, didn't I?" she mumbles.

Adora laughs. "A little bit. I was kind of into it, though."

Catra groans, then turns in Adora's arms to inspect her handiwork. Adora can't help but take pleasure in how groggy she seems.

"Yeah…that's rough." Catra leans forward and plants a few soft, clumsy kisses onto the base of Adora's neck. "Sorry, baby."

Adora's entire body thrills at the simplicity of those words. She immediately presses her lips to Catra's forehead. "S'OK. I had fun."

When she lowers her gaze, she sees Catra looking at her beneath hooded eyes. There's a small, crooked grin on her face.

"You didn't think we were done yet, did you?"

She brings a finger forward and begins to trail it down Adora's throat.

Adora's heart begins to pound again. She is suddenly hyperaware of the tension that's been pooling in her lower body all afternoon, try as she might to ignore it. But it's not as simple as she wants it to be. It never is.

"You, uh…you probably don't want to worry about me," Adora rushes, as Catra's finger trails below her clavicle. "I'm kind of not worth it."

She hadn't meant for it to sound like that. From the look on Catra's face, it landed about as poorly as she'd suspected; she looks stunned.

"I didn't mean it like that," she insists. Catra brings her arms to rest on Adora's shoulders, brow cocked. "I just, uh…I've never gotten off with just hands before. So it would probably take too long."

Catra gives her a strange, searching look. Adora has to resist the urge to fidget uncomfortably beneath her gaze.

"So you did mean it like that," Catra says quietly. She brings her hands into Adora's hair, stroking against her scalp. "You think it's not worth it to make you feel good. Just because it might take a while."

Adora sighs, embarrassed. The steady movement of Catra's fingers weaken her resolve. "I just don't want to exhaust you for no reason. Or make you think it's your fault, somehow."

Catra doesn't respond. She brings one hand down to pet Adora's cheek with her knuckles. "How do you get off when you're alone?"

She was afraid that Catra would ask that. She feels the blood pooling in her face; she has to clear her throat. "It's, uh - I don't know. It's kind of weird."

Catra's expression doesn't even budge. "Can you only get off with aggressive triple penetration?"

Adora nearly chokes on thin air.

"I - what? No. Obviously not."

A small smile breaks through Catra's deadpan.

"Because I'll do it, you know." Her smile grows. "I'd have to get creative. Maybe grab a few cucumbers from the fridge. But I'd do it for you, babe. No hesitation."

Adora can tell she's turning crimson. She covers as best she can by shoving Catra's shoulder. "Shut up. It's not - no. It's not that."

Catra's looking unrepentantly smug now. "Well, I'm guessing it's not any weirder. So come on. Tell me."

Adora exhales loudly. She's struggling to look Catra in the eyes. She tries to focus on the gentle sensation of her fingers as she speaks.

"I -" She rolls her eyes, flustered. "I have to like…use. Things."

Catra's brows shoot even higher.

"Gonna need a bit more than that."

Adora groans. She leans forward and buries her face in Catra's shoulder. She can't bear to make eye contact.

She feels Catra sigh. Her fingers continue their easy, soothing strokes.

"You don't have to tell me." Another stroke. "But it's probably not as bad as you think. And even if it is, I'm still down to try."

Adora feels her mind beginning to slip into an easy stupor. Catra's so sweet. She wishes she didn't have to be weird and embarrassing. Catra deserves better.

Finally, she exhales in a huff.

“I have to grind on things.”

Catra freezes. Her fingers still completely in Adora’s hair. It sends a surge of anxiety through Adora’s gut, all the way down to her toes

Then, to her horror, Catra starts *laughing.*

“Adora.” She wraps her in a tight hug, her chest shaking against Adora’s own. “I literally hate you.”

Adora has never been more confused in her life. She makes a weak, strangled noise of protest against Catra’s neck.

“What are you talking about?”

Catra pulls back. There’s a massive grin on her face.

“That’s not weird, dummy.” She pokes Adora in the stomach. “It’s literally completely normal. Like, lesbians do it *all the time.”*

Relief floods Adora’s system. “Really?

Catra can’t seem to hold back anymore; she starts tickling Adora’s sides, provoking a few high-pitched giggles.

“I can’t - believe - you thought - that was *weird,*” she enunciates, poking a different part of Adora’s torso. Adora is laughing hard enough to bring tears to her eyes. “Have you never seen lesbian porn before?”

Adora is howling now. “No!” she shrieks, dodging Catra’s fingers. “I - haven’t. Get - *off* of me.”

Catra finally relents, though not before giving a final prod to Adora’s side. They cackle for a while, limbs tangled as they both fight to catch their breath. Adora feels a deep sense of relief,

despite the embarrassment and adrenaline coursing through her system. At least Catra didn't think she was some sort of freak.

And then, gradually, she realizes that Catra's thigh has come to rest between her legs.

Her laughter dies in her chest. Catra seems to realize what's happened around the same time; her eyes darken as they scan Adora's face.

They breathe for a moment. Adora becomes aware, piece by piece, of her position. The feeling of Catra's breath on her skin. The brush of her nipples against her chest; how solid they feel.

Without thinking, she shifts forward to press her front against Catra's hip.

Catra's breath catches. She wraps a hand around Adora's waist and tugs her closer, thumb trailing over her skin. "You're OK," she murmurs. "It's OK."

Adora hesitates. Then she bears down, bit by bit, in a slow, experimental roll. She exhales as a spark travels through her center at the contact.

"Good," Catra whispers. Her voice wobbles a bit. "Good girl. Take what you need."

A pleasant shiver runs through the length of Adora's body.

She begins to push against Catra's hip - slowly at first, still hesitant, then in earnest as she falls into a rhythm. Soon, her trepidation fades away as lust starts to cloud her mind.

There's something primal about it - getting off on Catra's body while they lie face-to-face, chests rubbing against each other. Catra starts off petting down Adora's back as she moves, stroking the divots in her muscles. But as Adora's pleasure increases, Catra seems to get carried away as well - her trails grow sharper until she's leaving light scratches on Adora's skin.

“Do you know how good you feel, Adora?” Catra breathes. There’s a low sort of desperation in her voice. “Do you even know how hot this is? Watching you fuck yourself against me?”

Adora moans quietly in Catra’s ear. Her thrusts become a bit more feverish; Catra responds by tightening her grip in Adora’s hair, tugging sparks against her scalp.

“You’re so fucking pretty,” Catra whispers eagerly. Adora’s breath comes in starts. “Such a sweet, pretty girl. I will *never* deserve you.”

Adora’s mind goes completely silent.

“Catra.” She mouths against her neck, totally breathless, as her hips jerk upward. “Catra - you’re -“

She cuts herself off with a moan as Catra’s hip lands right where she needs it. Her leg pushes forward between Catra’s, almost reflexively; Catra gasps at the sudden contact, then wraps herself tight around Adora’s leg

“I’ve got you, baby.” Her hands tighten even more in Adora’s hair. “You’re doing so good. You’re - you’re so good, Adora.”

She is lost now. Her thrusts are no longer voluntary; she is making the kinds of sounds she wouldn’t even dare in private, choked and desperate and full of unfiltered pleasure. But she doesn’t care. She is so, incredibly close, and right now, she doesn’t care about anything.

“*Fuck*.” Catra is completely incoherent herself. She pulls Adora so tight she fears she’ll break. “You’re so beautiful. You’re so fucking - god. *Fuck,* Adora.”

Adora goes hurtling over the edge.

It’s the best thing she’s ever felt. Hitting her peak with Catra’s fingers in her hair - it’s like flying. Pleasure courses through her in waves, flooding her body with pure bliss. Her hips still for a

moment, then roll a few more times, chasing the feeling to its fullest extent.

Catra's peak comes a few seconds later - Adora hadn't even realized how close she was until she'd worked through her own. She holds Catra close while she fucks herself through the aftershocks on Adora's thigh, soft groans escaping her lips with every thrust. Watching it is almost better than her own climax. Their breath mingles as they ride the waves together, chasing pleasure without thought.

Their comedown is slow. She realizes Catra's been muttering in her ear - sweet, mindless nothings about how *good* and *beautiful* and *perfect* she is. The words carry her back down to Earth, depositing her softly into Catra's arms. All the tension leaks out of her body, draining through the mattress and into the floor below.

And then…stillness.

Neither of them move. Not an inch. Adora's body feels like concrete; she's never been so content in her life. She just tunes in to the rise and fall of Catra's chest against her, and lets her thoughts fade, one by one.

But it feels wrong, drifting off like this. She needs to acknowledge this moment somehow; give a name to what she's feeling. So before either of them can fall too deep into a stupor, Adora speaks.

"You were wrong." She lets her thumb trail lazily along the surface of Catra's skin. "About earlier."

She can practically feel Catra's brow furrowing. But she doesn't move. She must feel pretty heavy too. "How?"

Adora smiles. Then, with the last of her strength, she lifts her lips to Catra's ear.

"You're not Beatrice," she whispers. "You're too sweet."

She presses a kiss against the shell.

Adora expects a grumble. Some kind of ironic response. So she's pleasantly surprised to feel Catra snuggle in, holding Adora close against her shoulder.

"I like you a lot," she sighs.

Adora's heart melts.

They don't move again. Sleep takes them both in minutes, dragging them under while they rest in each other's arms. And for the first time in a very long while, Adora doesn't remember any of her dreams.

Maybe she doesn't need them as much anymore.

. . .

They wake up around midnight, still tangled up in each other. And Catra nearly has a heart attack.

The odds of her mom coming home before closing hours are slim to none. But it's far too close for comfort, and Catra's in a bit of a panic as she retrieves both their tops from the floor. Adora understands. She can't imagine what her parents would do if they caught her half-naked in bed with another girl - and they aren't even alcoholics.

But the fear is unfounded; the house is as silent as it was when she arrived. So after a few steadying breaths, they make their way through the cramped living room and emerge onto the front porch.

Neither of them are quite sure what to say to each other as they stand at the doorway. But it's nowhere near as tense as the last time they were together. There are no more secrets between them, now - no games. The atmosphere is shy but pleasant as they bid each other farewell.

As Adora moves to head towards her car, Catra speaks.

“Who do you think would’ve won?”

Adora turns. Catra has a curious smile on her face.

“The game,” she clarifies - though she doesn’t need to. “If we hadn’t gotten interrupted. Who would’ve won?”

Adora doesn’t think.

“I would’ve.”

Catra rolls her eyes at that. Her arms cross over her chest.

“Yeah? What makes you so sure?”

Adora stares at her. Her eyes are just as radiant in the night as the day, if not more so. Even post-nap, she’s the most stunning person Adora’s ever met.

Adora tells the truth.

“I got to kiss the most beautiful girl I know for ten minutes behind a locked door,” she shrugs. “That’s winning.”

Catra’s features soften.

“Get out of here, sap.” The fondness in her voice is obvious. “You’re gonna make me hurl.”

Adora can’t stop her own grin from spreading across her face. She bites her lip.

“You love me,” she says teasingly.

Catra’s eyes widen.

Adora’s heart skips a beat. Maybe it’s a little too soon for that word - in any context. She clears her throat. Better to quit while she’s ahead.

“Bye, Catra,” she says, an embarassed smile on her face. She turns before Catra has the chance to see the pink in her cheeks. After making her way down the sidewalk and fumbling with her keys a moment, she sticks one in the opening.

Seconds later, a warm mass collides with her back.

Adora grins. Catra is tiny - her forehead only goes to the base of Adora’s neck when she hugs her. Adora closes her eyes as Catra’s arms loop around her waist beneath her jacket.

“Bye,” Catra squeaks. Her voice is muffled against Adora’s back.

Adora turns. Then, forgetting herself a moment, she cups Catra’s jaw and leans forward to kiss her.

They probably shouldn’t linger as long as they do. It’s risky, outdoors. But Adora can’t help it, overcome as she is, and Catra makes no move to stop her. They press their lips together for what feels like hours, slow and easy, with nothing but the sound of crickets and cool night breeze to interrupt them.

She really likes this girl, she thinks to herself, as they hold each other close. She might like her more than she’s ever liked anyone, or anything. And it should probably scare her more than it does, but right now, it just feels…right. For the first time in a long while, Adora is willing to accept whatever the future has in store.

When their eyes finally open, both of them are breathless.

“You’re gonna get the cops called on me,” Catra murmurs. But her dumb smile contradicts the statement. “Go away. Lesbian.”

Adora grins as she climbs into her car.

They never did settle on a scene, Adora realizes, as she pulls away from Catra’s house with an overenthusiastic wave. Nor did she leave herself much time to glue down the trim. She’s going to have a busy few days; probably some late nights, too.

But she got a few hours of sleep in, laying with Catra. Good ones. And if Adora's being completely honest, she wasn't planning on resting much tonight, anyways. Not when she can spend her hours lying in bed, running through the day's events on loop, and figuring out how to make them happen again.

She doesn't know what's going to happen to her in the next few weeks. Odds are, not all of it will be good; there is still darkness waiting for her at home. But at the very least, she'd gotten to share that burden with someone else today. And with any luck - if she *really* played her cards right - she'll have someone to stand by her side throughout it all. A hand to hold in the dark.

As far as party games go, this one could've ended up a whole lot worse.

Chapter End Notes

I love gay ppl, and being gay

thanks for reading ❤️ ❤️ ❤️

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